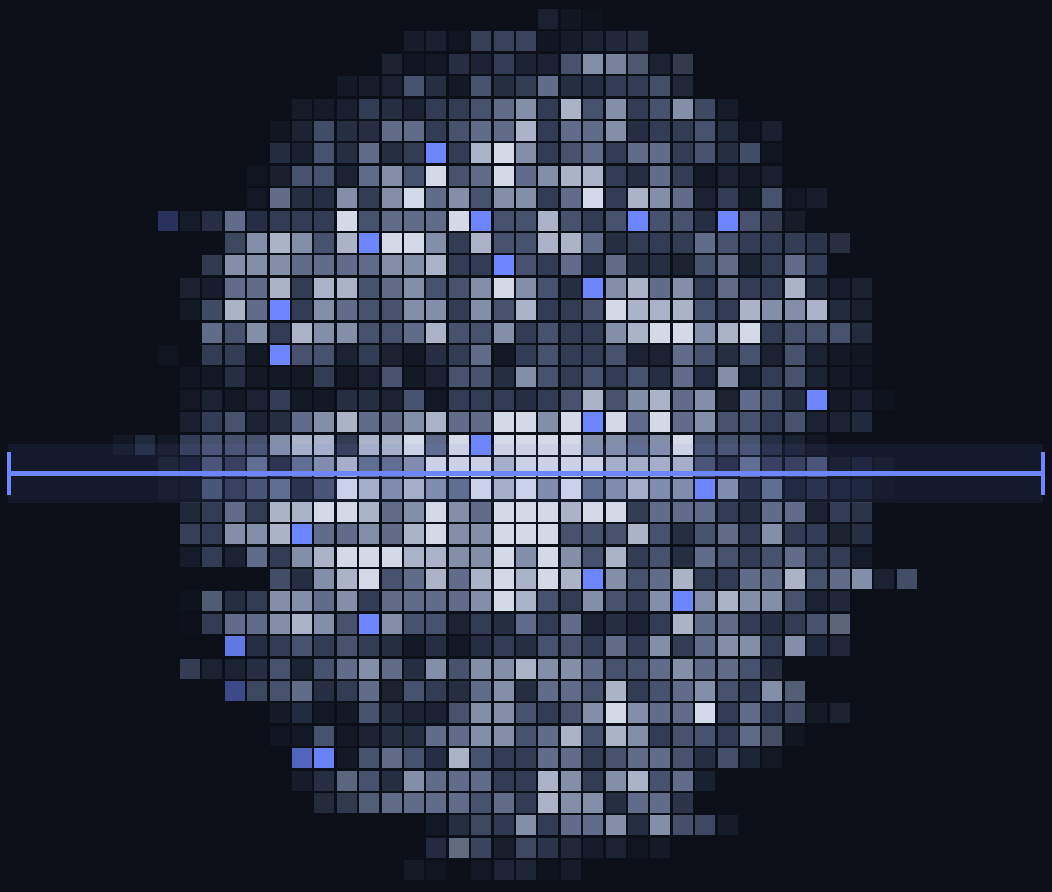
A DISSERTATION ON PHILIP K. DICK'S A SCANNER DARKLY (1977)



NOBODY'S THANKSGIVING

Forensic Apperception, the Industrialization of Lethe, and Acephalic Anamnesis in Philip K. Dick's A Scanner Darkly



OCTOBER 2026

βλέπομεν γὰρ ἄρτι δι᾽ ἐσόπτρου ἐν αἰνίγματι, τότε δὲ πρόσωπον πρὸς πρόσωπον· ἄρτι γινώσκω ἐκ μέρους, τότε δὲ ἐπιγνώσομαι καθὼς καὶ ἐπεγνώσθην.

For now we see through a glass, darkly; but then face to face: now I know in part; but then shall I know even as also I am known.

1 CORINTHIANS 13:12

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FRONT MATTER

Abstract

This dissertation argues that Philip K. Dick's *A Scanner Darkly* (1977) is the terminal document of a subject-form that Western thought assembled from two ancient operations: Pauline self-examination before an all-seeing judge, and Odyssean self-preservation through the cunning assumption of the name "Nobody." Against the three dominant critical frames — the novel as *roman à clef* of the post-1960s drug subculture, as dystopia of surveillance, and as clinical fable of hemispheric dissociation — it contends that the text is organized by a coherent, largely covert theological-philosophical architecture whose coordinates are fixed by a single letter of Paul. The title transposes 1 Corinthians 13:12 ("now we see through a glass, darkly"); the final sentence of the narrative reserves a gift for Thanksgiving, *eucharistia*, and thereby recalls 1 Corinthians 11:23–32, the earliest written account of the eucharistic *anamnēsis*, a passage that also commands the communicant to examine himself, diagnoses a failure to "discern the body," and attributes weakness, sickness, and death ("many sleep") to unworthy consumption. Between these two chapters stands 1 Corinthians 12, with its prohibition of *schisma* in the body and its image of a body that has become wholly eye. Read against this matrix, Dick's novel emerges as a negative Corinthian liturgy: its consumption is anti-sacramental, its self-examination forensic, its body schismatic, its face a mask, and its dead, like Paul's, asleep.

Three concepts are developed to articulate this structure. *Forensic apperception* designates the displacement of the Kantian "I think" by an institutional record compiled from the third-person standpoint, so that the subject comes to know itself only "as I am known" (1 Cor 13:12b) by the State; the holo-scanner is accordingly read as a *counterfeit eschaton*, a technological immanentization of the Lockean "Great Day" on which "the secrets of all hearts shall be laid open," which delivers total visibility of acts and no access whatever to consciousness. *The industrialization of Lethe* designates the conversion of oblivion — Homer's lotus, Plato's River Ameles, the river of carelessness — from mythic boundary into cultivated commodity within a carceral-therapeutic-pharmacological complex whose logic is the Derridean *pharmakon* and whose victim is the *pharmakos*. *Acephalic*

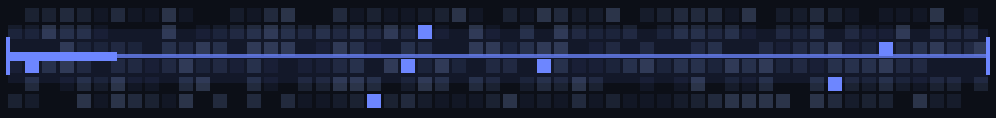
anamnesis designates the remembrance-without-a-rememberer enacted when Bruce, the residue of Bob Arctor, conceals a single blue flower of *Mors ontologica* in his shoe as a present for his friends, in an interior region the narration marks as invisible to anyone. Read through the Hymn of the Pearl, the Myth of Er, the recognition-scene of Odysseus's scar, Ignatius of Antioch's *pharmakon athanasias*, Novalis's *blaue Blume*, and Derrida's aporia of the gift, this gesture discloses the novel's only eschatology. Because the gift, on Derrida's account, is possible only on condition of absolute forgetting, the oblivion manufactured by Substance D becomes the condition of the one uncalculating act in a narrative otherwise saturated by information, exchange, and betrayal: the pharmakon turns over a final time. The keystone of the argument is the concept of care — Socratic *epimeleia*, Heideggerian *Sorge*, Pauline *merimna* — whose extinction is the precise content of the drug's street name, "Death," and of its botanical name, ontological death.

Situating the novel within its philosophical genealogy (Heraclitus, Plato, Paul, Augustine, Descartes, Locke, Hume, Kant, Hegel, Kierkegaard, Marx, Nietzsche, Bergson, Weber, Heidegger, Sartre, Adorno and Horkheimer, Lacan, Foucault, Deleuze, Derrida, Nagel, Parfit), its scientific substrate (the commissurotomy research of Sperry, Gazzaniga, and Bogen), its historical occasions (the institutionalization of the drug war, the Synanon-model therapeutic community, the Nixon tapes), and a comparative constellation of speculative and philosophical fiction (Hoffmann, Hogg, Poe, Stevenson, Chesterton, Kafka, Huxley, Orwell, Burroughs, Burgess, Kesey, le Carré, Lem, Disch, Le Guin, Wolfe, Pynchon, Wallace), the dissertation concludes that the Author's Note completes the structure by converting the novel itself into the flower: a pharmakon carried out of the field of death and offered, in anamnesis, to those whom Paul would say sleep. *A Scanner Darkly* is thus read as a negative Eucharist, a commemoration of the dead structurally homologous with the liturgical diptychs — Nobody's Thanksgiving.

CHAPTER ONE

Introduction

Prosōpon pros Prosōpon



βλέπομεν γὰρ ἄρτι δι᾽ ἐσόπτρου ἐν αἰνίγματι

For now we see through a glass, darkly.

1 CORINTHIANS 13:12

The argument of this dissertation can be compressed into a sentence: *A Scanner Darkly* is a negative liturgy of the Corinthian correspondence, in which every term of Paul's eucharistic and eschatological grammar — self-examination, discernment of the body, communion, remembrance, the face-to-face — reappears as its technological or institutional counterfeit, and in which the sole uncounterfeited act is a gift performed by a man who, in every sense the novel's institutions recognize, no longer exists. The remainder of this introduction locates that claim historically, critically, and methodologically.

01 The Text and Its Occasions

Dick drafted the novel at speed in 1973 and spent the better part of three years revising it; Tessa Dick, his fifth wife, later recalled a first draft completed in under two weeks and a protracted, collaborative rewriting. Doubleday published it in 1977 in seventeen chapters followed by an Author's Note. Its setting is Orange County in 1994, a future at seventeen years' remove, close enough that the estrangement it practices falls less upon the world than upon the self that inhabits it. The narrative follows Bob Arctor, an undercover narcotics agent who, under the code name Fred and inside a "scramble suit" that dissolves his features into a ceaseless composite of other faces, is assigned to surveil a household of users that is his own; who becomes addicted, in the line of duty, to Substance D, known on the street as "Death"; whose cerebral hemispheres are found under departmental testing to be in "competition"; and who is finally delivered — by Donna Hawthorne, the dealer he loves, who has been a federal agent throughout — to New-Path, a rehabilitation organization that renames him Bruce, assigns him to agricultural labor, and is disclosed in the final chapter to be cultivating, among its rows of corn, the blue-flowered plant *Mors ontologica* from which the drug is derived.

The biographical substrate is not incidental to this design but constitutive of it. After the departure of his fourth wife, Nancy Hackett, in 1970, Dick's house in Santa Venetia, Marin County, became a way station for young users of amphetamine and other drugs. In November 1971 the house was burglarized and his fireproof file cabinet blown open; among the culprits Dick entertained over the following years — radical militants, right-wing paramilitaries, the intelligence services — was, on at least one occasion, himself. The hypothesis is the novel in embryo: an investigator who cannot exclude himself from the list of suspects. In February 1972 he delivered "The Android and the Human" as guest of honor at a science fiction convention in Vancouver, attempted suicide there some weeks later, and entered X-Kalay, a residential recovery program modeled on Synanon; by

spring he had relocated to Fullerton, in the Orange County the novel would occupy. Dick maintained in interview that everything in the book he had actually witnessed, and the Author's Note converts that testimony into an obligation: it names friends dead or permanently damaged, records beside each name either death or a lasting injury — psychosis, brain damage, pancreatic or vascular damage — in the manner of a casualty list, includes the author himself among the injured with permanent pancreatic damage, disclaims any bourgeois moral, likens the people it mourns to children who go on playing in the street while one after another of them is struck down, frames misuse as a decision rather than a disease, of the kind involved in stepping out in front of a moving car, laments a punishment out of all proportion to the fault, and declares that Dick is not a character in the novel but the novel itself.

The public occasions are equally exact. On 17 June 1971 Richard Nixon named drug abuse "public enemy number one"; in 1973 New York enacted, at Governor Nelson Rockefeller's urging, drug laws that imposed mandatory sentences of fifteen years to life for selling or possessing relatively small quantities of narcotics, and on 1 July of that year the Drug Enforcement Administration was constituted by executive reorganization. The surveillance state, meanwhile, was undergoing an involuntary self-exposure. The March 1971 burglary of an FBI field office in Media, Pennsylvania, disclosed COINTELPRO; on 16 July 1973 Alexander Butterfield revealed to the Senate Watergate Committee that the President had been recording his own conversations; an eighteen-and-a-half-minute erasure in one of those recordings became the most celebrated lacuna in American archival history; and the release on 5 August 1974 of the conversation of 23 June 1972 compelled a resignation four days later. The years of the novel's composition thus coincide with the most spectacular instance in modern politics of a sovereign undone by an apparatus of self-surveillance he had himself installed. In 1974, too, Timothy Leary, the high priest of psychedelic liberation, agreed to inform for the FBI on former associates; and Dick wrote to the FBI proposing that "Stanisław Lem" was not an individual but a composite manufactured by a Party committee — a scramble suit projected onto the literary field.

Between draft and revision falls the event Dick called 2-3-74. In February and March 1974, recovering from oral surgery performed under sodium pentothal, he opened his door to a woman delivering medication from a pharmacy, saw the *ichthys* pendant at her throat, and underwent what he would later describe, in Platonic vocabulary, as *anamnēsis*: the loss of forgetting. That the theophany arrived as a pharmacy delivery is an irony the present study will not leave unremarked. The thousands of pages of the *Exegesis*, and *VALIS* (1981), followed. *A Scanner Darkly* therefore stands at the hinge between the secular paranoia of the 1960s

novels and the gnostic theology of the late work. This dissertation argues that the theology is already present in it — in the negative, as the outline of a letter that has not yet arrived.

02 The State of the Question

Criticism has approached the novel along five principal roads. The biographical-elegiac reading, consolidated by Lawrence Sutin and given novelistic form by Emmanuel Carrère, treats the book as testimony and memorial. The ideology-critical tradition inaugurated in *Science Fiction Studies* by Darko Suvin and developed by Peter Fitting, Carl Freedman, Kim Stanley Robinson, and Fredric Jameson reads Dick's ontological instability as a cognitive mapping of late capitalism, Freedman influentially construing paranoia not as pathology but as the epistemology proper to a social order in fact governed by concealed agencies. The postmodern and posthumanist readings — Jean Baudrillard, who named Dick among the writers of the third order of simulacra; Scott Bukatman's "terminal identity"; N. Katherine Hayles's account of the boundary work between human and android; Christopher Palmer's "exhilaration and terror of the postmodern" — locate the novel in the dissolution of the liberal subject into screen and code. Laurence Rickels has brought psychoanalysis and media theory to bear; Umberto Rossi has anatomized the novels' narrative ontologies; Erik Davis has restored Dick to the esoteric drug culture of the 1970s. Most recently, readers have mobilized Deleuze and Guattari's "botched" Body without Organs and Catherine Malabou's account of neuroplasticity to describe the protagonist's disintegration and his ambiguous reintegration on the New-Path farm.

Four lacunae are common to these approaches. First, the Pauline intertext is treated as the source of a title rather than as an architecture; I know of no reading that has observed that the novel's final word, *Thanksgiving*, returns the reader to the same epistle, and specifically to the chapter in which Paul transmits the words of eucharistic remembrance. Second, theological interpretation of Dick has been reserved almost entirely for the post-1974 corpus, as though *A Scanner Darkly* were the last secular novel rather than the first negative theology. Third, the ending has been read either as unrelieved devastation or as a thin thread of plot — the agency's wager that a burned-out husk, admitted precisely because he is harmless, will carry evidence out of the farm — rather than as an act possessing the structure of the gift. Fourth, the Author's Note has been treated as paratext: moving, extrinsic, biographical. The present study reads it as a structural member of the work and, finally, as its liturgical completion.

03 Method: Literalization, Constellation, Homology

Samuel R. Delany observed in 1969 that the sentences of science fiction license literal readings that mundane fiction forecloses: "her world exploded" may describe the fate of a planet. Dick's method in *A Scanner Darkly* is a philosophical extension of this license. He literalizes the governing figures of the philosophical tradition. Hume's bundle of perceptions becomes a garment; the internalized inspector of Foucault's *Surveiller et punir*, published in the year of the novel's revisions, becomes a man officially assigned to watch himself; the metaphysical "split" in the self becomes a functionally severed commissure; Lethe becomes a crop. The first task of interpretation is therefore genealogical: to return each literalized figure to the text in which it originated, in order to measure precisely what literalization does to it.

Suvin defined science fiction by the interplay of estrangement and cognition and by the *novum* whose validation through scientific logic distinguishes the genre from myth. The nova of *A Scanner Darkly* — scanner, suit, substance — are validated by the neuroscience and the surveillance technology of the early 1970s; but their estranging force is introverted. The world of 1994 is scarcely altered; it is the self that has become unrecognizable. The second task is accordingly comparative, and here I adopt the methodological image of Walter Benjamin's *Trauerspiel* study: ideas stand to things as constellations stand to stars. The comparative works assembled below are not, for the most part, "influences" — Dick's reading is documented only intermittently — but stars whose configuration with the novel discloses an idea that none of them states alone. The third task is formal: to show that the novel's narration, nomination, and generic modulation perform what its themes describe. The fourth is synthetic: to propose concepts adequate to the configuration so disclosed.

A note on citation. The novel is paraphrased rather than extensively quoted and is referenced by chapter. Classical and scriptural texts are cited by their standard numerations (Stephanus, Bekker, Diels-Kranz, the Akademie and Adam-Tannery editions, chapter and verse). Translations from Greek, Latin, German, and French are my own unless otherwise indicated; English scripture follows the Authorized Version of 1611, whose "glass" Dick's title retains.

04 The Argument

My thesis is that *A Scanner Darkly* dramatizes the terminal crisis of what I shall call the Corinthian-Odyssean subject: the self constituted, in the West, by the conjunction of two operations. The first is Pauline: the examination of oneself before a

judge who will at the end of time see the heart "face to face." The second is Odyssean: the preservation of oneself through cunning self-effacement, which Homer encodes in the pun that binds *Outis*, "Nobody," to *mētis*, "cunning." Both operations depend upon the refusal of oblivion — the lotus, Lethe — and both are secured by memory, whether as *anamnēsis* or as *nostos*. Dick imagines a regime in which these operations have been technologized. Self-examination becomes self-surveillance by an apparatus that simulates the Last Judgment; the Odyssean name "Nobody" becomes a State-issued garment, so that the agent preserves himself only by abolishing himself; and the lotus is no longer refused but farmed.

The outcome is not the "split personality" of the Romantic and Victorian double, which presupposes two substantial selves, but the collapse of the integrative function itself: the centre that, in Yeats's line, cannot hold. Against this closed circuit, the novel's final gesture — a flower slipped into a shoe as a present reserved for Thanksgiving, in an interiority the narration marks as visible to no one — is read as an acephalic anamnesis whose precondition is the very forgetting the drug produces. The gift becomes possible because the giver is gone.

The chapters proceed as follows. Chapter II reconstructs the philosophy of personal identity that the scramble suit literalizes (Hume, Descartes, Locke, Kant, Augustine, Spinoza, Nietzsche) and its neurological intertext (Sperry, Gazzaniga, Bogen, Nagel, Parfit), and introduces *forensic apperception*. Chapter III demonstrates how nomination, narration, and generic modulation enact fragmentation at the level of form. Chapter IV reads the scanner through the history of the gaze, from Plato's cave and the *Alcibiades* to Bentham, Foucault, Sartre, Lacan, Deleuze, and Baudrillard, and introduces the *counterfeit eschaton* and the *Outis-dialectic*. Chapter V reads New-Path as *pharmakon* and Arctor as *pharmakos*, and introduces the *industrialization of Lethe*. Chapter VI assembles the comparative constellation. Chapter VII performs the negative Corinthian reading of 1 Corinthians 11–13. Chapter VIII reads the blue flower as *acephalic anamnesis* and as the gift given in forgetting. Chapter IX reads the Author's Note as the novel's diptych and draws the consequences for Dick studies, for the philosophy of personal identity, for surveillance studies, and for the theory of addiction.

CHAPTER TWO

II

The Bundle and the Forensic Term

Personal Identity after the Scramble Suit



It is a forensic term, appropriating actions and their merit.

LOCKE, ESSAY II.XXVII.26

The scramble suit is the Humean self made into a uniform, and the history of the man who wears it is the history of what befalls the Lockean "forensic" person once an institution has taken the Kantian "I think" into its own custody. This chapter reconstructs those three moments, together with the neurological discourse through which Dick validated them, and introduces the first of this study's concepts: *forensic apperception*.

01 The Suit as Bundle

The novel's scramble suit is a membrane wired to a data bank of physiognomic fragments — eyes, noses, mouths, hair, complexions, ages, sexes — which it projects across the wearer's surface in a succession so rapid that the observer registers only a shifting composite, a blur that is every face for a fraction of a second and therefore no face at all. Its official justification is anticorruption: narcotics agents must be anonymous even to one another, so that none can be bought or blackmailed. Its ontological content is more radical. Hume reported that whenever he entered most intimately into what he called himself he stumbled upon some particular perception, never upon a self, and concluded that the mind is "nothing but a bundle or collection of different perceptions, which succeed each other with an inconceivable rapidity, and are in a perpetual flux and movement" (*Treatise* 1.4.6). The scramble suit is that sentence realized as fabric. It presents its wearer to every other subject as Hume found himself: a flux of appearances without a substratum, a theater — to retain Hume's own figure — in which perceptions "pass, repass, glide away, and mingle," but of whose place, as Hume immediately conceded, we have not the most distant notion.

Hume's second thoughts are as pertinent as his first. In the Appendix to the *Treatise* he confessed that his account of personal identity had led him into a "labyrinth": he could neither surrender the principle that distinct perceptions are distinct existences nor discover any real connection among them, and so could not explain what binds the bundle. Dick's novel answers Hume's question with the neuroscience of its decade — the binding is the commissure between the hemispheres — and then severs it. The scramble suit and Substance D are in this sense two halves of one experiment: the suit externalizes the bundle for others, the drug dissolves its binding for the self. Crucially, the suit is not a private aberration but an institutional ontology. Because no agent knows who any other agent is, the agency can assign Fred to surveil Bob Arctor without anyone — Fred included, eventually — registering that the surveillant and the surveilled are one. The novel's plot is made possible by an anonymity regulation; its tragedy is administered Humeanism.

William James observed that a man has as many social selves as there are individuals who recognize him (*The Principles of Psychology*, 1890, ch. 10). The scramble suit reduces that number to zero. Because no one can recognize its wearer, he has no social self at all; at the agency Fred exists only as a code name attached to a function. The first self the suit dissolves is the one that lives in other people's recognition, and the drug then dissolves the rest.

02 Hats and Coats

In the Second Meditation Descartes looks down from his window at men crossing the street and observes that, strictly speaking, he sees nothing but hats and coats — *pileos et vestes* — beneath which automata might be concealed; he judges them to be men, and the judgment belongs not to sight but to the mind (AT VII 32). The scramble suit universalizes this scene within the agency. Every colleague is a hat and coat that could conceal an automaton, a corrupted officer, or oneself, and the collegial trust on which the institution runs is a Cartesian judgment with no veracious God to underwrite it. The superior to whom Fred reports, Hank, is likewise suited; neither ever sees the other. Their encounters are adjudications between two cloaks.

Descartes's automaton returns, in Dick's 1972 Vancouver address, as a moral category: the "android" is the human being who has been reduced to reflex, predictability, and obedience, and who can therefore be used. The trajectory of *A Scanner Darkly* is the trajectory from hats and coats to the thing beneath them. In the final chapter the narration likens the burned-out man to an insect sprayed with toxin, a reflex machine circling forever and repeating its last instruction — the Cartesian *bête-machine* exactly, now produced rather than presupposed. And the Cartesian *malin génie*, the deceiver who might fabricate an entire world in order to mislead a single mind, has its institutional analogue in an operation that, by the novel's end, is shown to have staged much of Arctor's world — including the woman he loves — for purposes he was never permitted to know.

03 The Forensic Term

Locke's chapter "Of Identity and Diversity," added to the second edition of the *Essay* in 1694, distinguishes the identity of a *man* — a living organism persisting through the continuous replacement of its matter — from the identity of a *person*, which "extends" exactly as far as consciousness can be extended backward to past actions and thoughts (II.xxvii.9–10). Personhood, Locke insists, is "a forensic term, appropriating actions and their merit" (II.xxvii.26): it exists in order that praise,

blame, reward, and punishment may find their proper object. Three of his thought-experiments map onto Dick's novel with startling precision.

The first is the case of incommunicable consciousnesses. If the same man had one consciousness by day and another by night, neither accessible to the other, Locke argues, "the Day and the Night-man" would be as distinct persons as Socrates and Plato (II.xxvii.23). Fred and Arctor are Locke's day-man and night-man: one the suited functionary of the agency, the other the householder of the night; and the novel's movement is the progressive closure of the passage between their consciousnesses until, in the testing room, Fred hears of Arctor as of a stranger. The second case is madness, which ordinary speech registers by saying that a man is "not himself" or "beside himself" (II.xxvii.20) — idioms Locke reads as folk confirmation that personal identity tracks consciousness rather than substance. Bruce is the limit of that idiom: the same man as Arctor, and on Locke's criterion not the same person.

The third case is the most consequential, for Locke chose intoxication as his paradigm of the forensic gap. Is a man drunk and sober the same person? Then why is he punished for what he did while drunk, though never afterward conscious of it? Locke's answer is that human judicatures punish with a justice suited to their way of knowing: they cannot distinguish the real from the counterfeit, so that "the fact is proved against him, but want of consciousness cannot be proved for him." Only "in the Great Day, wherein the secrets of all hearts shall be laid open," will no one be made to answer for what he knows nothing of (II.xxvii.22). The passage contains, in compressed form, the moral argument of the Author's Note — punishment annexed to the man rather than to the person, to the proven fact rather than to the unprovable consciousness — and it identifies with precision the epistemology of the holo-scanner. The scanner is the perfect instrument of the human judicature as Locke describes it: it proves facts against a man with total fidelity and can prove nothing whatever about consciousness. That it should nonetheless arrogate to itself the totality of vision which Locke reserves for the eschaton is the subject of Chapter IV.

04 The "I Think" in Custody

Kant's transcendental deduction turns on a proposition whose German must be given entire: *Das: Ich denke, muß alle meine Vorstellungen begleiten können.* The "I think" must be able to accompany all my representations, for otherwise something would be represented in me that could not be thought at all, and the representation would be either impossible or at least nothing for me (B131–132). The original synthetic unity of apperception is thus the condition under which there is any-

thing like an objective world for a subject. Now consider Fred in the safe apartment, reviewing the holo-scanner record of Arctor's house. He confronts representations of his own body, his own acts, his own speech; and his "I think" can no longer accompany them *as his*. They are, in Kant's terms, representations in him that are nothing for him. But Dick adds what Kant could not: they do not thereby become nothing. They become something *for the State*. The institution's case file, which gathers Arctor's acts under a name and a docket number, supplies the synthesis the subject can no longer perform. The file is the State's transcendental unity of apperception.

I call this condition *forensic apperception*: the condition in which the unity of a subject's representations of itself is no longer produced by the subject's own synthetic activity but supplied, from the third-person standpoint, by an institutional record that collects its acts under a name, so that the subject knows itself, if at all, only as it is known. The final clause anticipates Paul (1 Cor 13:12b), and deliberately. Forensic apperception also inverts Kant's critique of rational psychology. The paralogisms expose the error of inferring from the merely formal unity of the "I think" to an intuited soul-substance (A341/B399 ff.). The scanner commits the opposite error in reality rather than in thought: it delivers an intuition of the self — a moving image of Arctor — from which every trace of an "I" has been subtracted. Rational psychology posited a subject without an intuition; the holo-scanner furnishes an intuition without a subject.

The practical philosophy is implicated as profoundly as the theoretical. In the third section of the *Groundwork* Kant argues that a rational being must regard itself from two standpoints: as belonging to the world of sense, and so subject to natural causality, and as belonging to the intelligible world, and so free (4:450–453). The two standpoints are the resolution of the Third Antinomy, in which freedom and universal causality are each demonstrable (A444/B472); their coexistence in one subject is what makes responsible agency thinkable. *A Scanner Darkly* distributes the two standpoints between two persons. Fred occupies the standpoint of the world of sense: for him Arctor is a causal system whose behavior is to be recorded, explained, and predicted. Arctor occupies the standpoint of freedom: he chooses, desires, decides. What Kant required to be held together in one consciousness has been institutionally divided, and the antinomy has accordingly become a schism. The division recurs at the level of the book. The Author's Note maintains, against the therapeutic vocabulary of the 1970s, that misuse is a decision; the narrative demonstrates, with clinical exactitude, a neurological determination. Paratext and text occupy the two standpoints, and the book contains its antinomy without resolving it.

The antinomy runs through the Author's Note itself, not only between the Note and the narrative. Its image for decision is an adult's single, lucid, catastrophic act: misuse, it says, is a decision of the kind involved in stepping out in front of a moving car, an error of judgment rather than a disease. Its image for the dead is the opposite: children who go on playing in the street while one after another of them is struck by traffic and killed or crippled — and Dick counts himself among those children. The first image assigns full agency; the second presupposes the absence of the knowledge that agency requires. The Note's own resolution is Greek. It refuses the word fate, on the ground that any of them could have stopped playing, and names what befell them Nemesis — retribution for a choice — while insisting that the retribution was beyond belief. Nemesis is the measure of tragedy, retribution proportioned to transgression; the Note invokes the measure in order to record its failure. The mourner insists on responsibility so as not to condescend to his friends, and on disproportion so as not to condemn them.

05 From Decision to Necessity

The tradition does, however, offer a resolution, and it is diachronic. Augustine describes his bondage before conversion as a chain forged by an enemy out of his own will, and analyzes its links with a precision no subsequent theory of addiction has surpassed: *ex voluntate perversa facta est libido, et dum servitur libidini, facta est consuetudo, et dum consuetudini non resistitur, facta est necessitas* — from a perverse will came desire; desire served became habit; habit unresisted became necessity (*Confessions* VIII.5.10). Decision becomes disease through habit. On the Augustinian schema the Author's Note and the narrative are both true, of different moments in a single history: the first link was forged by a will, the last by nothing but the weight of the links before it.

Spinoza supplies the corrosive counterpoint. The drunk, he observes, believes that he speaks from the free decree of the mind things which, sober, he would wish he had left unsaid (*Ethics* III, P2, Scholium); the felt experience of deciding is merely ignorance of the causes by which one is determined. On Spinozist terms the Author's Note's "decision" is a retrospective illusion. Yet Spinoza's own remedy — freedom as adequate knowledge of one's causes — sharpens the novel's horror, for in *A Scanner Darkly* the only adequate knowledge of Arctor's causes is held by the State, which has engineered, recorded, and exploited them. Aristotle had already observed that the incontinent man possesses knowledge in one sense and not in another, like the sleeper, the madman, or the drunk who can recite the verses of Empedocles (*Nicomachean Ethics* VII.3, 1147a10–24). The household's interminable, learned-sounding disputations — over a bicycle's missing gears, over

Barris's baroque theories of who is informing on whom — are Empedocles recited by the drunk: the syntax of knowledge with no knower behind it.

Nietzsche completes the reversal of Locke. There is no being behind doing, he writes; *"der Thäter" ist zum Thun bloss hinzugedichtet* — the doer is merely invented and added to the deed (*Genealogy* I.13) — and the invention serves punishment, which requires a subject who could have done otherwise. The holo-scanner records deeds. The forensic apparatus adds the doer. "Bob Arctor" is, by the novel's final third, exactly such an addition: a name the institution attaches to recorded acts after the agent who performed them has dissolved, so that someone may be held answerable.

06 The Severed Commissure

Dick validated his novum with the most prestigious neuroscience of his moment. From the early 1960s Roger Sperry, Michael Gazzaniga, and Joseph Bogen studied patients whose corpus callosum had been surgically divided to control intractable epilepsy, and found that under laboratory conditions each hemisphere could be shown to perceive, learn, and respond in ignorance of the other (Sperry 1968; Gazzaniga 1970; Bogen 1969). Robert Ornstein's *The Psychology of Consciousness* (1972) popularized the findings as a duality of the analytic and the intuitive. In the novel, departmental psychologists submit Fred to perceptual tests and diagnose a "competition" between his hemispheres: each processes the world independently, and the deficit is not a lesion within one person but the coexistence of two perspectives, each unaware of the other's jurisdiction. The alternation of Fred and Arctor is given a cortical address.

Philosophy took the measure of these patients in exactly the years of the novel's conception. In "Brain Bisection and the Unity of Consciousness" (1971), Thomas Nagel tested every available hypothesis — one mind, two minds, one mind with an automaton attached, an oscillation between them — found each inadequate, and concluded that the question how many minds such a patient has may admit of no whole-number answer, our ordinary concept of a single person resting on a unity that is contingent rather than guaranteed. Arctor is a Nagelian case: neither one nor two. Derek Parfit drew from the same cases, and from fission thought-experiments, the reductionist conclusion that personal identity is not what matters; what matters is psychological connectedness and continuity, his "Relation R" (*Reasons and Persons*, 1984). Parfit famously described his conversion to this view as a liberation, the dissolving of the walls of a glass tunnel in which he had felt himself confined. Dick's novel is the same discovery made in terror rather than relief, through a glass not dissolved but darkened, and it presses fur-

ther than Parfit: when identity dissolves, Relation R dissolves with it. The question of what, if anything, remains when both are gone is the question of the novel's final page, to which Chapter VIII will return with an answer Parfit does not give — not connectedness but care.

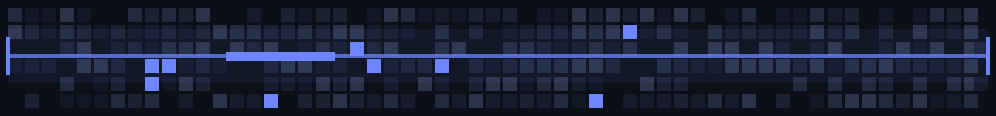
Two further contemporaneous models complete the field. Julian Jaynes's *The Origin of Consciousness in the Breakdown of the Bicameral Mind* (1976) proposed that early humans experienced the commands of one hemisphere as the voices of gods; in Dick's agency the commanding voice emanates from a superior who is a voice without a face, the bicameral god reconstituted as bureaucrat. Daniel Dennett's later account of the self as a "center of narrative gravity" (1992) — a theoretical abstraction posited by the stories a body tells about itself — names exactly what Arctor loses as the narration's own capacity to name him stably fails, which is the subject of the next chapter. The cumulative result of this genealogy is a subject that knows itself only as it is known: forensic apperception as the terminal form of the Western philosophy of personal identity, and the Lockean deferral of judgment to the Great Day collapsed into the present tense of the surveillance tape.

CHAPTER THREE

III

Form as Fragmentation

Nomination, Narration, and the Comic Machine



du mécanique plaqué sur du vivant

the mechanical encrusted upon the living

BERGSON, LE RIRE

A Scanner Darkly does not merely represent the disintegration of a subject; its narration, its naming, and its generic modulation perform that disintegration upon the reader. This chapter demonstrates the formal homology on five levels: reference, voice, comedy, genre, and name, before closing on the medium-specific homology achieved by Richard Linklater's adaptation.

01 Nomination and Reference

The narration designates its protagonist by institutional position. Inside the suit, at the agency, he is "Fred"; in the house, "Arctor" or "Bob Arctor"; at New-Path, "Bruce." Saul Kripke's lectures of 1970, published as *Naming and Necessity* (1972; 1980), argued that proper names are rigid designators, fixed to their bearers by an initial act of baptism and transmitted thereafter along a causal chain of usage, so that a name picks out the same individual in every possible world. Dick's novel enacts a counter-Kripkean semantics. Its names are non-rigid: "Fred" designates whatever occupies a particular suit and code; "Bruce" is fixed by a literal baptism, New-Path's renaming of its residents, which deliberately severs the causal chain linking the new name to the old life. Reference tracks role rather than individual, and the reader, who must constantly decide whom a given name designates, is made to perform the very act of identification at which Fred progressively fails.

The novel inscribes the logic of this failure in its institutional rules. Because agents are anonymous even to their superiors, Fred must report on Bob Arctor exactly as he reports on everyone else in the house; were he to exempt Arctor, the exemption would itself betray who Fred is. The anonymity regulation designed to protect the agent's identity therefore *requires* him to treat himself as a suspect. Self-surveillance is not an accident of the plot but the condition of the name's secrecy. It is accordingly fitting that the climax of nomination arrives as incredulity: when Hank, suited, suggests to Fred, suited, that the man under investigation is Fred himself, Fred cannot credit it. Earlier, reviewing holo-footage, he has experienced the converse vertigo, glimpsing the man in the house and grasping, as though for the first time, that this is how Fred looks without the suit.

02 Voice and Transcript

Dorrit Cohn's term for the technique that dominates the novel is the "narrated monologue" (*Transparent Minds*, 1978): a third-person narration that adopts the idiolect, tense, and evaluative coloring of a character's consciousness without marking the transition. Bakhtin had already identified in such discourse a structurally double-voiced word, in which two intentions, the narrator's and the character's,

inhabit a single utterance. Dick exploits the double-voicedness of free indirect discourse to make the split a property of syntax. A sentence that begins in the agency's procedural idiom ends in the household's argot; a pronoun that designated Fred at the start of a paragraph designates Arctor by its close. The reader cannot determine, at many junctures, who is thinking — which is exactly the epistemic condition of the protagonist.

A second formal device extends the homology. At intervals the household's conversations are rendered in dramatic notation, with speakers' names in capitals and parenthetical stage directions, as though transcribed from a tape. In these passages the novel's prose becomes a surveillance transcript; the reader occupies Fred's chair. The documentary insertions accumulate across the book — the departmental test protocols, the Lions Club address delivered from within the suit, the closing Author's Note — so that the text assembles itself, in the manner of a Burroughsian cut-up, out of heterogeneous records. The book wears its own scramble suit.

03 The Comic Machine

The first half of the novel is among the funniest Dick wrote. It opens with a man who spends an entire day shaking aphids out of his hair, then showering, then collecting the insects in jars for a physician who can find none: delusional parasitosis, the formication of stimulant psychosis, staged as farce. Charles Freck, planning a dignified suicide that will indict the society that failed him, swallows what he believes to be barbiturates, receives instead a hallucinogen, and spends what he takes to be his final hours confronted by an extradimensional being reciting the catalogue of his sins. The housemates conduct a quasi-scholastic disputation over the missing gears of a cheaply acquired bicycle. Barris, the household's resident theoretician, builds devices, constructs proofs, and proposes conspiracies with the inexhaustible fertility of a mind that has detached inference from evidence. Somebody — Barris is suspected — damages Arctor's prized "cephscope," a device for viewing one's own brain patterns as color, and later Arctor's car fails dangerously on the freeway: the instrument of self-seeing broken, the vehicle of self-direction sabotaged.

Bergson located the source of laughter in *du mécanique plaqué sur du vivant*, the mechanical encrusted upon the living, and catalogued its procedures: repetition, inversion, the reciprocal interference of series (*Le Rire*, 1900). The household is a comic machine in precisely this sense. Its dialogues run on loops; its inferences proceed with mechanical rigor from absurd premises; two conversations interfere until neither participant knows which he is in. Heidegger, for his part, analyzed

everyday fallenness through three modes: *Gerede*, idle talk, which has lost its relation to what it talks about; *Neugier*, curiosity, which never dwells; and *Zweideutigkeit*, ambiguity, in which no one can tell what has genuinely been understood (*Sein und Zeit* §§35–37). The household's talk is *Gerede* in its purest form, and its comedy is the comedy of Dasein entirely given over to the they.

The novel's tragic turn is the conversion of the Bergsonian comic into the Dickian android. For Bergson the mechanical is *encrusted upon* the living, which remains beneath it and laughs at its own rigidity; in Dick's final chapter the mechanical has *replaced* the living, and the image of the man as an insect circling under toxin, repeating its last instruction, is Bergson without laughter. Bakhtin's carnival offers a parallel diagnosis. Carnival suspends hierarchy, celebrates the grotesque body, and renews the world through its periodic overturning, after which Lent restores order. The household is carnival without renewal; New-Path is the Lent that follows, a Lent without Easter.

The insect frames the book. It opens on a man covered in insects only he can see and closes on a man the narration compares to an insect circling under toxin. Between the two, Kafka's *Die Verwandlung* (1915) is completed in slow motion. Gregor Samsa wakes as vermin after a single night; Dick's protagonist takes the length of the novel, and the vermin, which begin outside the body as a delusion, end as its form.

04 Trauerspiel, Not Tragedy

Aristotle held that the finest tragic plot unites reversal and recognition, *peripeteia* and *anagnōrisis*, and his paradigm was the *Oedipus Tyrannus* (*Poetics* 11). Sophocles' play is also literature's first investigation in which the investigator is the culprit, and *A Scanner Darkly* reproduces its structure with uncanny fidelity: a man charged by the city with finding a source of pollution discovers, by his own inquiry, that the polluted source is himself; and the instrument of sight, which in Sophocles is the blind seer Tiresias, becomes in Dick a sightless machine that sees everything. But Dick withholds the recognition. Fred is told that he is Arctor and cannot believe it; the anagnorisis is formally completed and phenomenologically void. Recognition passes over the protagonist's head to the reader. Oedipus blinds himself because he has seen; Arctor is blinded by the apparatus of seeing. I call this structure *anagnorisis without a recognizer*, and it marks the novel's exit from the genre of tragedy.

The genre it enters is the one Walter Benjamin reconstructed in the *Ursprung des deutschen Trauerspiels* (1928). The baroque mourning-play, Benjamin argued, is not tragedy: its figures are not heroes in agon with myth but creatures exposed to

history as natural decay; its sovereign is paralyzed by indecision; its characteristic mode is allegory, in which meaning shatters into fragments each of which can signify any other, so that allegories are in the realm of thought what ruins are in the realm of things. The scramble suit is allegory become garment: a face shattered into interchangeable fragments, each able to signify any other. The dead of the Author's Note are not tragic heroes whose fate answers to a commensurate flaw. Dick does reach for the tragic name — he calls what befell them Nemesis, not fate — but only to record that the retribution outran every measure; he refuses a bourgeois moral; and they remain creatures, punished, in his phrase's sense, far beyond any fault. And the Author's Note itself is *Trauer*: mourning, the affect that names the genre. The final chapter adds a coda in a further mode, a dark georgic in which a laborer works the soil and the harvest is death.

05 Onomastics

The names, whether or not each resonance was intended, cohere with the design. *Arctor* is one letter from *actor*, the undercover agent's vocation; it also recalls the Greek *arktos*, bear, and *Arktouros*, Arcturus, whose name means the bear's guardian or watcher (*ouros*): the name of the protagonist encodes a watcher watching. *Bruce*, New-Path's baptismal name, unwittingly preserves the old one, since the most famous Bruce in the language is Robert the Bruce, and Bob is Robert: the renaming that was meant to sever the chain of reference keeps a link of it alive. *Donna Hawthorne* bears the name of a flowering shrub, the hawthorn through whose hedge Proust's narrator first glimpses Gilberte at Tansonville, so that in *Du côté de chez Swann* the hawthorn frames the first appearance of the beloved's face; and of an American novelist whose subject was secret guilt under a community's gaze. The novel that opens its love story with a flower's name closes its plot with a flower. *Substance D* is "Death" on the street, and in the Lions Club address Fred glosses the letter as an acrostic of ruin in which death is accompanied by despair and by the desertion of friends, of each by every other — a gloss the final sentence, with its present for friends, will answer. The phrase also invites a philosophical reading: Spinoza's single Substance, *Deus sive Natura*, in which finite modes have no independent being, and Aristotle's primary substance, the individual this-man, which the drug destroys. *New-Path*, finally, renders *hodos*, the "Way" by which the earliest Christians named their movement (Acts 9:2); and Heraclitus warned that one would not find the limits of the soul though one traveled every road, so deep is its logos (DK B45).

06 The Rotoscope as Scramble Suit

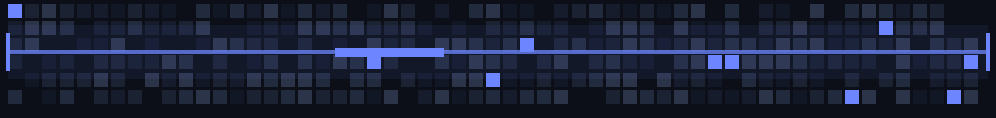
Linklater's adaptation (2006), like his *Waking Life* (2001), was produced by interpolated rotoscoping: live-action footage traced and painted over by animators using Bob Sabiston's software. The technique is a medium-specific scramble suit. Every face in the film is at once photographed and drawn, indexically present and graphically effaced, so that the uncanny instability of the animated image reproduces, at the level of the medium, the instability the suit produces at the level of the diegesis. The film also condenses into a single figure what the novel leaves structurally parallel: in private, Hank removes the suit and is revealed to be Donna, so that the beloved and the superior become two faces of a single apparatus. The adaptation is further reported to let Dick's own likeness flicker once across the suit's composite — a visual gloss on the Author's Note's claim that its author is not a character in the novel but the novel itself.

CHAPTER FOUR

IV

Polyphemus’s Eye

Surveillance, the Counterfeit Eschaton, and the Outis-Dialectic



Οὖτις ἐμοί γ’ ὄνομα

Nobody is my name.

ODYSSEY 9.366

The holo-scanner is the last term in a history of the gaze that begins in Plato's cave and ends, in Dick's own decade, with a President undone by his own tapes. This chapter traces that history in order to isolate what is new in Dick's apparatus. It is a machine that simulates the Last Judgment — the *counterfeit eschaton* — operated by an agent whose survival depends upon being Nobody — the *Outis-dialectic*.

01 The Cave and the Pupil

In the seventh book of the *Republic*, prisoners chained since childhood watch shadows cast upon a wall by artifacts carried before a fire behind them, and take the shadows for reality (514a–520a). Fred in the safe apartment, before a bank of monitors projecting three-dimensional images of the house, is the prisoner of the cave, with a single and decisive modification: the shadows are of himself. He never turns toward the fire — the apparatus that produces the images and the purposes for which it does so remain concealed from him until the end. And the Platonic ascent is parodied with terrible exactness in the final chapter. Bruce is led out of the enclosure into open fields under the sun, and the thing made visible there, the source at last disclosed, is the flower of death. The cave's outside is a plantation; the Good, when it finally appears, is the poison's root.

The *Alcibiades I*, whose authenticity is disputed but which antiquity read as the threshold of Platonism, interprets the Delphic command to know oneself through an optical analogy. An eye sees itself when it looks into another eye, for the face of the beholder appears in the pupil opposite as in a mirror; the Greeks named the pupil *korē*, "girl" or "doll," for the little image it holds. So too the soul knows itself only by looking into another soul, and into its best and most divine part (132c–133c). Self-knowledge is constitutively mediated by another's eye. Arctor seeks himself in the gaze of Donna, who will not allow herself to be touched; and the woman in whose eye he hopes to find his image is, it emerges, the eye of the State. The *korē* is a federal agent. The scanner has usurped the place of the other's eye.

Shakespeare gives the Platonic figure its political edge. "The eye sees not itself," Brutus concedes, "But by reflection, by some other things"; and Cassius at once offers himself as Brutus's "glass," which will "discover to yourself / That of yourself which you yet know not of" (*Julius Caesar* 1.2). The mirror is held by a conspirator, and its revelation is a recruitment. Barris, who presents himself at headquarters to disclose to the suited officers a portrait of Arctor as the hub of a vast conspiracy — unaware that one of the officers is Arctor — is Cassius: the manipulative glass. Wittgenstein formalized the impossibility that Shakespeare dramatizes. The subject, he wrote, does not belong to the world but is a limit of it; nothing in the

visual field permits the inference that it is seen by an eye (*Tractatus* 5.631–5.633). The holo-scanner places the eye inside its own visual field as an object among objects. What is, for Wittgenstein, a metaphysical confusion becomes, lived, a psychosis. The cephscope, the device by which Arctor contemplated his own brain patterns as color, is the same scandal in miniature, and it is fitting that someone breaks it.

Heraclitus gave the classical task its shortest form: *edizēsamēn emeōuton*, I searched out myself (DK B101). Fred performs the same search, outsourced and on tape. Pascal traced the whole unhappiness of human beings to a single cause, their inability to stay quietly in a room (*Pensées*, 1670). Fred can stay in his room only by watching himself on its screens.

02 The Inspection-House

Bentham's *Panopticon* (1791) describes a circular building whose cells are wholly visible from a central lodge whose inspector is wholly invisible, so that each inmate, unable to know when he is watched, must conduct himself as though he always is; its preface announces "a new mode of obtaining power of mind over mind, in a quantity hitherto without example." Bentham was also the author of the felicific calculus, and Dick's agency is Benthamite in both senses. It watches, and it calculates. In the final chapter Donna and the federal agent Mike Westaway confront the arithmetic of their operation: New-Path admits only the harmless, only burned-out husks; there was no other way in; whether anything has been accomplished is uncertain; it had to be done. A man has been spent for the many on the strength of a wager.

Foucault made the Panopticon the diagram of disciplinary power (*Surveiller et punir*, 1975). The visible inmate, he argued, assumes power's constraints as his own, playing both parts of the relation within himself until he becomes the source of his own subjection. Dick literalizes and then exceeds this account. In Foucault the doubling of roles is a figure for internalization, presupposing a unified subject who internalizes. In Dick it is an organizational chart: Fred is the inspector, Arctor is the inmate, and the internalization runs not through a conscience but across the corpus callosum. The novel shows what Foucault's figure conceals — that an internalization which succeeds completely does not produce a docile subject but divides the subject into its two roles. Foucault's subsequent claim that the West made of man a confessing animal (*La Volonté de savoir*, 1976) completes the picture: Fred's reports on Arctor are confessions in the third person, the self producing its truth for a power that receives it, under the formal guise of evidence against another.

Nietzsche gave the reversal its moral form. Whoever fights monsters should see to it that he does not become one; *und wenn du lange in einen Abgrund blickst, blickt der Abgrund auch in dich hinein* — and if you gaze long into an abyss, the abyss also gazes into you (*Jenseits von Gut und Böse* §146). The narcotics agent who gazes long into the household becomes its addict. The watcher is watched by what he watches, and finally by himself.

03 The Look Without Return

Sartre's analysis of the look (*L'être et le néant*, 1943) turns on a man absorbed in spying through a keyhole, wholly given to what he sees, without reflection. Footsteps sound in the corridor; he is seen; in an instant he becomes an object in another's world, and shame is the lived recognition that he is the object the Other sees. *A Scanner Darkly* closes the keyhole scene upon itself. The voyeur looks through the keyhole and sees himself. The look returns, but from no Other; there are no footsteps in the corridor. Shame, which requires the co-presence of the seer and the seen in one consciousness under another's gaze, becomes impossible, and in its place appears a structural shamelessness — the Greek *anaideia*, the absence of the *aidōs* that is the social face of the self's being-seen — experienced by the protagonist as estrangement rather than as guilt. The household is a *huis clos*, and Sartre's most quoted line, "l'enfer, c'est les autres," is revised: hell is oneself as an other.

Hegel had already specified why the look cannot return from a machine. *Das Selbstbewußtsein erreicht seine Befriedigung nur in einem andern Selbstbewußtsein* — self-consciousness achieves its satisfaction only in another self-consciousness (*Phänomenologie des Geistes*, §175). Recognition requires a recognizer who could withhold it. Arctor seeks confirmation of himself from an apparatus that can record but not recognize, and reports to a superior who is a mask. The struggle for recognition, which in Hegel produces lord and bondsman, cannot even begin: its only parties are a camera and a cloak.

Lacan's mirror stage (1949) describes the infant's jubilant assumption of its specular image as an anticipated unity, an Ideal-I, set against the lived experience of the fragmented body, the *corps morcelé*, and founded on misrecognition. The holo-scanner runs the mirror stage backward. The specular image, instead of unifying, disintegrates; the fragmented body returns twice, as uniform in the suit and as footage on the monitors; and the misrecognition is complete, since the subject misrecognizes not an idealized self but himself as a stranger.

04 The They and the Dividual

Heidegger's *das Man*, the anonymous "they" in which everyday Dasein is dispersed, receives in *Sein und Zeit* its most compressed formula: *Jeder ist der Andere und Keiner er selbst* — everyone is the other, and no one is himself (§27). The scramble suit is the uniform of *das Man*: a face that is everyone's because it is no one's. Heidegger adds that the they disburdens Dasein of its responsibility, since it was always "they" who decided. Dick's agency is accordingly an institution of responsibility constructed upon the anonymity of *das Man* — a paradox that the plot converts into catastrophe when the anonymous responsible party turns out to be the irresponsible suspect.

Deleuze's "Post-scriptum sur les sociétés de contrôle" (1990) — whose central term he borrowed from Burroughs — announced the passage from disciplinary enclosure to control: continuous modulation, codes rather than signatures, the decomposition of the individual into "dividuals" and of the mass into samples, data, and banks. The scramble suit is the dividual worn as skin, a person represented as a statistical sample drawn from a bank of features. New-Path is a hinge institution between the two regimes: an enclosure in the disciplinary sense that operates by continuous modulation in the control sense, since its cure is never completed and its residents are never discharged, only reassigned.

Baudrillard's precession of simulacra (*Simulacres et simulation*, 1981), in which the map precedes and engenders the territory, describes the agency's file with precision. Arctor is surveilled because the operation requires a suspect whose degradation will make him admissible to New-Path; the record manufactures the reality it purports to document. Baudrillard himself named Dick among the writers of simulation, and the novel's Orange County, home of the theme park Baudrillard read as an imaginary staged so that the rest might be believed real, is its proper landscape. Dick's own definition, from his 1978 essay "How to Build a Universe That Doesn't Fall Apart Two Days Later," is the most exact gloss: "Reality is that which, when you stop believing in it, doesn't go away." By that criterion the footage is real and the self is not: the record persists when no one believes in it, whereas Arctor is precisely what goes away.

05 The Sovereign's Tapes

The public analogue was being enacted as Dick wrote. A President installed a voice-activated recording system to document his own conversations for history; the recordings became the evidence that ended his tenure; and an erased segment, never recovered, became the emblem of the archive's lacuna. Arctor's amnesia is

the human form of that gap: a hole in the record of the self that no technician can restore. Francis Ford Coppola's *The Conversation* (1974) ends with the surveillance expert Harry Caul dismantling his own apartment in search of a listening device he cannot find, playing the saxophone amid the wreckage — the surveiller become the surveilled, the instrument of listening turned against the listener. Antonioni's *Blow-Up* (1966) had already shown the photographic record, enlarged in pursuit of a hidden truth, dissolving into the grain of its own medium. The footage of Arctor behaves in the same way. The more closely Fred examines it, the less of a person it contains.

The Author's Note draws this connection itself. It calls the habit of sitting around with friends, talking while tape recorders ran, the decade's bad decision, and it says the decision was made both inside and outside the establishment. The household and the White House were recording themselves in the same years. Dick would later rewrite that President as Ferris F. Fremont, the demagogue of *Radio Free Albemuth* (written 1976; published 1985), and read his fall into the cosmology of the *Exegesis* and *VALIS*.

06 The Counterfeit Eschaton

Paul's sentence divides time in two: *βλέπομεν γὰρ ἄρτι δι' ἐσόπτρου ἐν αἰνίγματι, τότε δὲ πρόσωπον πρὸς πρόσωπον* — "For now we see through a glass, darkly; but then face to face: now I know in part; but then shall I know even as also I am known" (1 Cor 13:12). The glass is a mirror (*esoptron*); in a culture of polished metal mirrors, in which Corinthian bronze was proverbial, it returned a dim and distorted likeness; and the image is *en ainigmati*, in a riddle. The present is the time of mediated, partial, enigmatic knowledge; the eschaton is the time of immediate, total, reciprocal knowledge — Locke's Great Day, on which the secrets of all hearts shall be laid open.

In the novel's eleventh chapter Arctor addresses the scanner directly. He asks what it sees — into the head, down into the heart — and whether clearly or darkly; he hopes, for everyone's sake, that it sees clearly, since he can no longer see into himself; and he reflects that if it, too, sees only darkly, they are cursed, and will go on dying knowing very little and getting that little wrong. The passage is the novel's theological center, and its structure is eschatological: Arctor invests the machine with the hope that belongs to the end of time. He wants the scanner to be the face-to-face.

Eric Voegelin, in *The New Science of Politics* (1952), diagnosed the modern political religions as gnostic in their transfer of transcendent fulfillment into history, an immanentization of the eschaton. The holo-scanner is an immanentized eschaton

in the strictest technical sense: the promise of total disclosure brought forward into the present and assigned to an apparatus. It is a *counterfeit* eschaton because it possesses the eschaton's scope together with the human judicature's epistemology. It sees every act and no heart. It is Locke's Great Day staffed by Locke's human court. I define the counterfeit eschaton accordingly as an apparatus that simulates the total and final disclosure which eschatology reserves for the end, while its vision remains restricted to external fact, so that it delivers judgment without knowledge of the heart — a Last Judgment in which the accused is known but never seen face to face. It is worth observing that Voegelin, the anti-gnostic, and Dick, who would become the most gnostic of American novelists, converge on this diagnosis from opposite directions. For both, the State that simulates final judgment is the archon of the age; Dick's later formula, that the Empire never ended, names the same structure from inside the prison.

The Pauline phrase has a further edge. *Prosōpon* is the Greek word for face, and also for the actor's mask; Latin rendered it *persona*, whence "person"; Boethius defined a person as an individual substance of a rational nature (*naturae rationabilis individua substantia*). When Fred and Hank, both suited, sit across a table, the scene is *prosōpon pros prosōpon* — face to face, mask to mask, person to person — in which neither mask is anyone's face. The eschatological encounter has been parodied by bureaucracy. And the second half of Paul's verse is realized in its own inversion: in the counterfeit eschaton the subject comes to know himself "even as also I am known" — but known by the apparatus. Forensic apperception is the epistemology of the counterfeit eschaton.

07 The Outis-Dialectic

The ninth book of the *Odyssey* contains, in sequence, the whole figural system of Dick's novel. Odysseus, trapped in the cave of the one-eyed Cyclops Polyphemus, tells him that his name is *Outis*, Nobody (9.366). Blinded, Polyphemus cries to the other Cyclopes that Nobody is killing him by guile; they answer that if no one (*mē tis*) is harming him, his trouble must come from Zeus; and Odysseus laughs in his heart at how his name and his flawless *mētis*, his cunning, deceived them (9.408–414). The pun is the hinge of Western cunning: *mē tis*, "no one," is *mētis*, "cunning intelligence." Marcel Detienne and Jean-Pierre Vernant, in the very year of Dick's revisions, reconstructed *mētis* as the polymorphous intelligence of disguise and the trap (*Les ruses de l'intelligence*, 1974). Horkheimer and Adorno had already read the episode as the primal scene of bourgeois subjectivity (*Dialektik der Aufklärung*, 1944/1947): Odysseus preserves himself by denying himself, affirms his identity by disowning it in the name Nobody, and so inaugurates a self whose survival is pur-

chased by an introversion of sacrifice, a self that saves itself by making itself nothing and therefore tends toward becoming nothing.

A Scanner Darkly is the terminal point of this Outis-dialectic. The scramble suit is a State-issued Outis: the agent preserves himself — from corruption, from reprisal — by becoming Nobody. But in Dick the Cyclops issues the disguise. The State gives its agents the Nobody-mask so that they may sit before the State's own single eye, and the cunning that in Homer blinds the eye is in Dick blinded by it. In Homer, Nobody escapes the cave clinging to the underbelly of a ram. In Dick, Nobody is led from one enclosure to another, and the self-renunciation that was meant to be strategic becomes literal: the man who survived as Nobody ends as nobody, a name without a self.

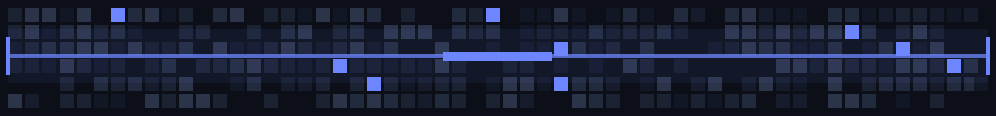
Immediately before the Cyclops, the same book narrates the Lotus-Eaters (9.82–104). Those of Odysseus's men who taste the honey-sweet fruit wish only to remain among the Lotophagi, browsing on lotus, *νόστου τε λαθέσθαι* — forgetful of their homecoming — and the verb of forgetting shares its root with Lethe. Odysseus drags them weeping to the ships and binds them beneath the benches. Dick's agency inverts the hero. Rather than dragging its man from the lotus, it tolerates and exploits his eating of it in the line of duty; and rather than leading him to the ships, it conducts him into the lotus fields. The single eye, the name Nobody, and the flower of forgetting: *A Scanner Darkly* is the ninth book of the *Odyssey* run in reverse. The next chapter follows the lotus to the field where it is grown.

CHAPTER FIVE

V

The Pharmakon and the Pharmakos

New-Path and the Industrialization of Lethe



οὔκουν μνήμης ἀλλὰ ὑπομνήσεως φάρμακον ηὗρες

You have found a pharmakon not of memory but of reminding.

PLATO, PHAEDRUS 275A

New-Path cures the addiction it produces; the scanner remembers what it causes the self to forget; the agency manufactures the addict it pursues. Each institution in the novel occupies the structural position of the Greek *pharmakon*, the drug that is at once remedy and poison, and the protagonist occupies that of the *pharmakos*, the human scapegoat expelled from the city for its purification. This chapter reads the institutions through Plato's *Phaedrus* and Derrida's commentary upon it, identifies the logic of the pharmacological sovereign, and introduces the second of this study's concepts: *the industrialization of Lethe*.

01 Theuth's Gift

In the myth Socrates recounts near the close of the *Phaedrus*, the Egyptian god Theuth presents writing to King Thamus as a *pharmakon* for memory and wisdom. Thamus replies that it will produce the opposite: it will implant forgetfulness, *lēthē*, in the souls of those who learn it, through neglect of the exercise of memory — *μνήμης ἀμελετησίᾳ* — since, trusting to external marks, they will no longer remember from within. *Οὔκουν μνήμης ἀλλὰ ὑπομνήσεως φάρμακον ηὗρες*: what you have found is a pharmakon not of memory but of reminding (274c–275b). The holo-scanner is Theuth's gift perfected. It is *hypomnēsis* without limit, a memory external to the soul that produces forgetting within it. Fred comes to rely upon the record and to lose the remembrance; the more completely the apparatus remembers Arctor, the less Arctor remembers himself. The word Thamus uses for neglect, *ameletēsia*, the absence of practice or care, will prove decisive below.

02 The Pharmacy and the Pharmacological Sovereign

Derrida's "La pharmacie de Platon" (1968; collected in *La dissémination*, 1972) demonstrates that the *pharmakon* is undecidable — remedy, poison, drug, philter, dye — and that Plato's philosophical project depends upon mastering it by separating its beneficial from its baneful senses, an operation the word itself defeats. Derrida extends the chain of the root to the *pharmakeus*, sorcerer and poisoner, and to the *pharmakos*, the scapegoat whom Athens expelled at the Thargelia in times of calamity as a purification of the city — a word absent from Plato's text yet present, Derrida argues, in its system. The *pharmakeion*, the pharmacy, is the storehouse where remedy and poison are kept side by side.

New-Path is a *pharmakeion*. It stores the remedy — rehabilitation — and the poison — the plantation — in one institution, and no position within it permits the two to be separated. Around it the novel assembles a single pharmacological economy: the dealer who is a federal agent and sells the drug to the man her operation

intends to spend, the user who is a narc, the department whose tests certify a decline it has been content to record, the clinic that grows the drug it treats. The State and the cartel are not antagonists within this economy but organs of it. Carl Schmitt defined the sovereign as the one who decides on the exception — *Souverän ist, wer über den Ausnahmezustand entscheidet* (*Politische Theologie*, 1922). The power that rules Dick's Orange County is a pharmacological sovereign: it decides on the dose.

03 Pharmakos

Arctor is the *pharmakos*. He is selected for a federal operation without his knowledge or consent, and the acts and the actors can be named. Donna Hawthorne, a federal agent working undercover as a dealer, is the dealer from whom he buys. She works the operation with Mike Westaway, a federal agent who has tried for a long time, and failed, to get inside New-Path. Because New-Path admits only the harmless, the role they need filled requires a burned-out man; they deceive Arctor while the burnout they depend on takes its course, and when it is complete Donna delivers him, in withdrawal, to the clinic. In their closing exchange the two agents call the deception a success and its cost unavoidable, though Westaway privately doubts that anything has been gained. The city's pollution, Substance D, is to be traced to its source and purged; Arctor's mind is the price, paid without his consent. René Girard's theory of the surrogate victim (*La violence et le sacré*, 1972) specifies the conditions: the victim must be marginal yet sufficiently an insider for his expulsion to stand in for the community's own; and the mechanism functions only if it is misrecognized by those who perform it. Arctor meets both conditions: a marginal insider, sacrificed by colleagues who do not tell him, and who tell themselves that there was no other way. But the secrecy alters the logic of the rite. A *pharmakos* whose expulsion no one witnesses purifies no one; the catharsis is withheld from the city, which does not know that it has been saved, if indeed it has been. Giorgio Agamben's *homo sacer* (1995), the life that may be killed but not sacrificed, offers the converse figure: Arctor is sacrificed, in his handlers' own understanding, but not killed. He is neither a ritual victim nor a murdered man. His is an administrative sacrifice.

Kant's formula of humanity names the wrong exactly: act so that you treat humanity, in your own person and in that of any other, always at the same time as an end and never merely as a means (*Grundlegung*, 4:429). Arctor is used merely as a means, without his knowledge, and the operation's only justification is consequential — one mind spent for a chance of finding the source. Chapter IV called the agency Benthamite in two senses, surveillance and calculus; here the calculus

meets the prohibition it cannot price. Westaway's private doubt is the novel's register of that remainder.

The handlers' own theology is revealing. In the novel's last movement, when it is suggested that Arctor should have passed through the doorway while he had the chance, Donna replies that he never had the chance: what was offered him was a promise, something better in a remote future — perhaps, she concedes, only after his death. The deferral is eschatological in form. The agency, which in the scanner has immanentized the Last Judgment, defers redemption to the far side of the grave. Judgment is brought forward; salvation is postponed. That asymmetry is the political theology of the counterfeit eschaton.

04 The Algebra of Need and the Alienated Harvest

In the testimony that prefaces *Naked Lunch* (1959), William Burroughs described junk as the ideal product, the commodity that requires no sales talk, governed by an "algebra of need"; and he observed that the junk merchant does not sell his product to the consumer but sells the consumer to his product. Dick literalizes the inversion. Bruce is sold to the product as its agricultural labor: the addict becomes the plantation hand of his addiction.

Marx's analysis of estranged labor in the manuscripts of 1844 describes the condition with precision: *der Gegenstand, den die Arbeit produziert, ihr Produkt, tritt ihr als ein fremdes Wesen, als eine von dem Produzenten unabhängige Macht gegenüber* — the object that labor produces, its product, confronts it as an alien being, a power independent of the producer. Marx enumerated four estrangements: from the product, from the activity of production, from species-being (*Gattungswesen*), and from other human beings. Bruce suffers all four in their purest form. He grows the substance that annihilated him without knowing what he grows; he works as the narration's insect circles, by reflex; his species-being, the capacity for conscious and free activity, has been extinguished; and he is isolated among the indifferent. It is against this fourfold estrangement that the final gift must be weighed: a present for friends is the minimal reconstitution of a relation to others, the last residue of species-being.

The young Marx also gave the century its most famous pharmacological metaphor. Religion, he wrote, is the sigh of the oppressed creature, the heart of a heartless world: *Sie ist das Opium des Volkes* ("Zur Kritik der Hegel'schen Rechtsphilosophie: Einleitung," 1844). *A Scanner Darkly* inverts and completes the formula. Synanon, the therapeutic community founded by Charles Dederich in 1958 whose techniques Dick encountered at X-Kalay in Vancouver, declared itself a religion in 1974, in the midst of the novel's revision; its signature practice, the Game,

subjected residents to collective verbal assault designed to break the will, and the novel's New-Path subjects Bruce to games of exactly this kind. In October 1978, a year after the novel's publication, two members of Synanon's paramilitary "Imperial Marines," Lance Kenton and Joseph Musico, put a rattlesnake, its rattles removed so that it would give no warning, in the mailbox of the Los Angeles attorney Paul Morantz; it bit him, and he was hospitalized. Three weeks earlier Morantz had won a $300,000 judgment against Synanon on behalf of a married couple, on claims that the organization had kidnapped the wife after she was referred to it for what she believed would be psychiatric treatment, held her against her will for nine days, coercively indoctrinated her, and tortured her. Dederich had repeatedly called for an attack on Morantz, as the Point Reyes Light, a small weekly newspaper whose Synanon coverage won the 1979 Pulitzer Prize for Public Service, reported. Dederich, Kenton, and Musico all eventually pleaded no contest to charges arising from the attack, and Morantz later described himself as one of some fifty victims of a campaign of violence against Synanon's critics between 1975 and 1978 (Janzen 2001; Mitchell, Mitchell, and Ofshe 1980). By then the founder who had made confrontation the method of cure had also made his members' bodies a matter of policy: after Dederich declared children a bad investment, women in the community were pressed to have abortions and men to undergo vasectomies. Historians of the United Farm Workers have documented Cesar Chavez's adoption of the Game within his union in the late 1970s — the confrontational therapy of addicts migrating into the organization of agricultural labor, an uncanny historical rhyme with New-Path's farm. In Dick's novel religion is no longer the opium of the people. The church grows the poppy.

Two further figures complete the portrait of the institution. Hegel's unhappy consciousness is consciousness of itself as a doubled and merely contradictory being — *das Bewußtsein seiner als des gedoppelten, nur widersprechenden Wesens* — and its passage beyond that condition runs through a mediator, a minister to whom it surrenders its own will, its property, and its enjoyment, thereby passing over into Reason (*Phänomenologie des Geistes*, 1807). New-Path performs the surrender — of name, possessions, and will — but there is no passage to Reason; there is only the field. It is the unhappy consciousness administered. And Dostoevsky's Grand Inquisitor, who relieves humanity of the unbearable burden of freedom by means of miracle, mystery, and authority, confesses to his silent prisoner the secret of his church: "We are not working with Thee, but with him — that is our mystery" (Garnett's translation). New-Path's mystery is the same. It does not work with the cure.

05 The Industrialization of Lethe

At the close of the *Republic* Plato's Er recounts that the souls, having chosen their next lives, march through a terrible heat to the plain of Lethe, a plain bare of trees and of everything that grows from the earth, and encamp at evening beside the River *Ameles*, whose water no vessel can hold. All must drink a measure; those not preserved by wisdom drink more than the measure; and whoever drinks forgets everything (621a). The river's name is precise. *Ameles* is *a-melēs*, the careless or unheeding, from the root of *meletē* and *melei*, practice, concern, care. The *Phaedrus*'s *ameletēsia* and the *Republic*'s Ameles share that root: in Plato, forgetting is the absence of care. Against both stands *epimeleia heautou*, the care of the self, which Foucault argued in the lectures of 1981–1982 was the matrix within which the Delphic "know thyself" originally stood (*L'herméneutique du sujet*). Dick's novel presents a regime of *gnōthi seauton* without *epimeleia heautou*: total self-knowledge by surveillance, total abandonment of the care of the self.

The plant's name, *Mors ontologica*, can now be translated exactly. It is not death in general but the death of care. Heidegger defined the being of Dasein as care, *Sorge* (*Sein und Zeit* §41), and distinguished Dasein's dying from the mere perishing (*Verenden*) of living things and from demise (*Ableben*), the physiological end of a human life (§49). *Mors ontologica* names a fourth category the existential analytic does not foresee: the extinction of care while the organism persists, Dasein deprived of the mineness (*Jemeinigkeit*, §9) that made its existence someone's. Bruce is the existence of an organism after the end of the structure that made it a self.

What is unprecedented in Dick is the agricultural form of this death. Plato's Lethe is a barren plain on which nothing grows; Homer's lotus grows wild in a distant land, and those who eat it do not work. Dick's Lethe is cultivated in rows and concealed among corn: oblivion as agribusiness, the poison hidden in the staple grain of the continent. Horkheimer and Adorno read the Lotus-Eaters as a figure of the utopia of a life without labor, which the self-preserving subject must renounce in order to constitute itself. Late capitalism, in Dick's vision, has abolished the renunciation by subsuming the utopia: the lotus-eaters are set to work in the lotus fields. I define *the industrialization of Lethe* accordingly as the conversion of oblivion from a mythic boundary — the river at the edge of life — into a cultivated, harvested, and distributed commodity, produced by the institutions that claim to cure it, with the forgetting subjects as its labor force.

Max Weber closed *Die protestantische Ethik und der Geist des Kapitalismus* (1904–1905) with the image of a casing hard as steel, the iron cage of rationalized life, and with a prophecy of its inhabitants: *Fachmenschen ohne Geist, Genußmenschen ohne Herz* — specialists without spirit, sensualists without heart, a nullity

that imagines it has attained a stage of humanity never before reached. *A Scanner Darkly* is populated by exactly these two classes, the narcotics agents and the users, and its protagonist is both at once: Fred the specialist without spirit, Arctor the sensualist without heart, Weber's two last men in a single body. Dick's later name for the iron cage, in *VALIS*, would be the Black Iron Prison.

06 The Chooser's Blame

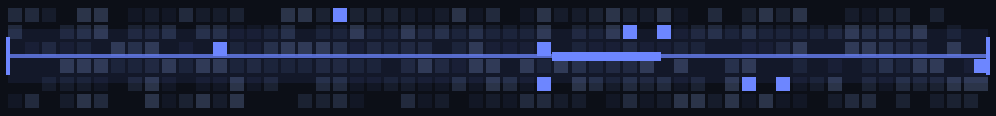
Before the lots are cast in the Myth of Er, a prophet proclaims the principle that governs the whole: *αἰτία ἑλομένου· θεὸς ἀναίτιος* — the responsibility is the chooser's; god is blameless (617e). The first soul to choose, one who had come down from heaven and had lived a virtuous life by habit without philosophy (*ἔθει ἄνευ φιλοσοφίας*), seizes the greatest tyranny without examining it, and discovers too late that it includes the eating of his own children; the souls that have come up from below, having suffered, choose with care (619b–d). The Author's Note occupies the prophet's position. It declares the chooser's responsibility — a decision, not a disease — while mourning those who chose ill. And Arctor's history reproduces that of the first chooser with eerie fidelity. A man virtuous by habit, a suburban husband and father, strikes his head on a kitchen cabinet and recognizes in a flash that he hates the house, the wife, the daughters, the whole life; he chooses the other life at once and without examination. Virtue by habit, unsecured by philosophy or care, collapses at a blow. Plato's *ethos* and Augustine's *consuetudo* converge: habit can carry virtue or vice with equal indifference, and what decides between them is not habit but care — which is precisely what *Mors ontologica* destroys.

CHAPTER SIX

VI

Comparative Constellations

The Double, the Drug, the Therapeutic State, and the Undercover Soul



Die Ideen verhalten sich zu den Dingen wie die Sternbilder zu den Sternen.

Ideas are to things as constellations are to stars.

BENJAMIN, URSPRUNG DES DEUTSCHEN TRAUERSPIELS

A Scanner Darkly stands at the intersection of six traditions of speculative and philosophical fiction, and in each it occupies a terminal or inverted position. This chapter assembles them not as a catalogue of influences but as a constellation in Benjamin's sense, in which the novel's place among the stars discloses the idea none of them states alone.

01 The Double: From Elixir to Commissure

The literature of the double begins, in its modern form, with a drug. In E. T. A. Hoffmann's *Die Elixiere des Teufels* (1815–1816) the monk Medardus drinks from a forbidden relic, the devil's elixir, and is thereafter shadowed by a deranged double whose crimes are imputed to him and whose identity he cannot disentangle from his own. James Hogg's *Private Memoirs and Confessions of a Justified Sinner* (1824) adds the theological and forensic dimensions. Robert Wringhim, assured by antinomian Calvinism that as one of the elect he is justified whatever he does, is accompanied by Gil-Martin, a shape-shifter able to assume any face, Robert's own included; and Robert suffers lapses of months in which, he is told, he committed seductions and murders of which he retains no memory. Gil-Martin is a theological scramble suit, and Robert is Locke's drunkard, held answerable for facts against which no consciousness can be pleaded. Poe's "William Wilson" (1839) ends with the narrator's murder of the double who has been his conscience, and with the dying double's declaration that the narrator has seen, in that image which is his own, "how utterly thou hast murdered thyself." Dostoevsky's *Двойник* (*The Double*, 1846) relocates the double to the bureaucratic office, where Golyadkin's replica usurps his post, his colleagues, and finally his existence: doubling as administrative replacement.

Stevenson's *Strange Case of Dr Jekyll and Mr Hyde* (1886) is the canonical pharmacological double, and the contrast with Dick is exact. Jekyll's premise is that "man is not truly one, but truly two"; his powder releases a second self already present, and the experiment ultimately fails because the original salt contained an unknown impurity that cannot be reproduced — the pharmakon's undecidability rendered as chemistry. Jekyll's metaphysics is dualist: the drug separates two substantial natures. Substance D releases no Hyde. There is no second self in Arctor waiting to be freed; there is only the integrative function, and the drug destroys it. Wilde's *The Picture of Dorian Gray* (1890) inverts the relation between subject and record: the portrait absorbs the consequences while the man remains unchanged. In Dick the record shows the decay to the subject, and the subject cannot recognize it as his.

Otto Rank's study *Der Doppelgänger* (1914; 1925) traced the double from an archaic insurance against death to a modern harbinger of it, and Freud adopted the thesis in "Das Unheimliche" (1919). Fred is the harbinger of Arctor's ontological death. Goethe had given German letters its formula for the divided self — *Zwei Seelen wohnen, ach! in meiner Brust, / Die eine will sich von der andern trennen* (*Faust I*, 1112–1113) — but Faust's two souls are two drives, both his own. Arctor's are two jurisdictions. Dostoevsky's Underground Man swore that to be too conscious is an illness; Arctor begins in that illness, watching himself watch, and ends in its opposite. Borges's "Borges y yo" (*El hacedor*, 1960), in which the public author steadily absorbs the private man until the narrator cannot tell which of them is writing the page, is the Fred–Arctor relation without the State; and Nabokov's *Despair* (1934; English 1937, revised 1965), whose narrator murders a tramp he believes to be his perfect double only to discover that no one else perceives the resemblance, is its exact inversion: in Dick, everyone but the protagonist can see that the suspect is himself.

The typology that emerges is the first result of the constellation. The Romantic and Victorian double presupposes two substantial selves, whether as souls or as moral natures, and its horror is the emergence of an other. Dick's double, informed by the commissurotomy research, presupposes no second self; its horror is the failure of integration, and the double is not an other who appears but a self that disappears into two partial perspectives. *A Scanner Darkly* is the first post-dualist novel of the double.

02 The Pharmacological State

Huxley's *Brave New World* (1932) established the State drug as an instrument of stability: soma pacifies openly, by policy. Substance D is soma in disguise — it appears to be the counterculture's vice and is in fact the product of an institution allied with order. Huxley's *The Doors of Perception* (1954) took its title from Blake — "If the doors of perception were cleansed every thing would appear to man as it is, Infinite" — and, following Bergson and C. D. Broad, conceived the brain as a reducing valve on Mind at Large, which mescaline opens; *Island* (1962) imagined a polity sacramentally organized around a benign *moksha*-medicine. *A Scanner Darkly* is the anti-*Island*, and its scanner is a door of perception that darkens. William James had observed in *The Varieties of Religious Experience* (1902) that "sobriety diminishes, discriminates, and says no; drunkenness expands, unites, and says yes." Substance D says neither yes nor no. It dismantles the one who might say either.

Two further texts complete a triad. Stanisław Lem's *Kongres futurologiczny* (1971; English 1974) imagines a psychochemical civilization in which masking

compounds conceal a ruined world beneath pharmacological illusions of plenty: the drug *conceals* the world from the subject. Dick's own "Faith of Our Fathers," written for Harlan Ellison's *Dangerous Visions* (1967), imagines a totalitarian state whose water supply is laced with hallucinogens; a dissident anti-hallucinogen reveals the Absolute Benefactor as a monstrous, devouring entity: the drug *reveals* the world to the subject. Substance D neither conceals nor reveals; it destroys the subject to whom the world might be concealed or revealed. Concealment, revelation, annihilation: the three positions exhaust the logical possibilities of the political pharmakon, and Dick's 1977 novel occupies the last. It is a historical irony worth recording that Lem was praising Dick in print as a visionary among the charlatans of American science fiction (1975) in the very period in which Dick was denouncing Lem to the FBI as a committee.

Thomas Disch's *Camp Concentration* (1968) presents political prisoners injected with pallidine, a derivative of the syphilis spirochete that produces genius and death in the same course; the narrator, Louis Sacchetti, records both. The State appears as pharmacological experimenter, as it does in Dick's agency, which treats Arctor's degradation as an operational variable. Daniel Keyes's *Flowers for Algernon* (1959; 1966) records a mind's rise and fall in the subject's own progress reports and ends with a request that someone put flowers on a laboratory mouse's grave. The diminished subject's final act is a gesture of care involving flowers; Bruce's will be another.

Dick's own corpus provides the most precise intertexts. In *The Three Stigmata of Palmer Eldritch* (1965), the colonists' drug Can-D "translates" them into miniature doll-worlds, and their disputes over whether the translation is real parody the controversies over transubstantiation; its rival, Chew-Z, imprisons users in worlds where Eldritch's stigmata — the artificial arm, the steel teeth, the mechanical eyes — appear on every face, and it is marketed with the slogan "God promises eternal life. We can deliver it." *Palmer Eldritch* is Dick's explicit anti-Eucharist; *A Scanner Darkly* is its naturalized, institutional successor, an anti-Eucharist with no deity behind it, only an organization. *Ubik* (1969) supplies the positive pole: a spray can that arrests the decay of reality and, in the epigraph to its final chapter, speaks in the cadences of the Johannine Logos. *Flow My Tears, the Policeman Said* (1974) supplies the exact chiasmus: Jason Taverner, after exposure to a drug that deranges space, wakes in a world in which no record of him exists — a man without a file. Arctor is a file without a man.

Two earlier works by Dick supply the remaining coordinates. In "The Minority Report" (1956) the State punishes crimes before they are committed, on the testimony of three "precogs" whose minds have been reduced to instruments, their babble transcribed by machines. *A Scanner Darkly* is its chiasmus: a State that pun-

ishes acts whose agent no longer remembers them, Locke's drunkard in place of Precrime's suspect; and Bruce, at the end, is a precog in reverse, a human instrument that has seen and cannot say. In *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* (1968) the bounty hunter administers the Voigt-Kampff test, an apparatus for detecting the absence of empathy, and his colleague Phil Resch, forced to submit to it, faces the possibility that the hunter is himself the quarry. Fred's discovery that the suspect is himself is Resch's fear come true.

03 The Therapeutic Sovereign

Ken Kesey's *One Flew Over the Cuckoo's Nest* (1962) names the therapeutic-carceral apparatus the Combine and its group therapy a "pecking party"; McMurphy's lobotomy is *mors ontologica* by surgery, and Chief Bromden's fog machine is hallucination as accurate perception of power. Bromden's final act of care for McMurphy is a mercy killing; Bruce's will be a flower. Anthony Burgess's *A Clockwork Orange* (1962) subjects Alex to the Ludovico technique, which removes the capacity to choose evil, and gives the prison chaplain the objection that a man deprived of choice has ceased to be a man. New-Path removes the capacity to choose at all. Ursula K. Le Guin's *The Lathe of Heaven* (1971), widely read as her dialogue with Dick, sentences George Orr — who has been obtaining drugs on borrowed pharmacy cards in order to suppress dreams that alter reality — to "Voluntary Therapeutic Treatment" under a psychiatrist who harnesses those dreams for his own designs: the drug as an attempt not to change the world, the therapist as the real danger.

Orwell's *Nineteen Eighty-Four* (1949) provides the surveillance novel against which Dick's must be measured. The telescreen separates watcher and watched; Dick unites them. O'Brien, the apparent ally who is the Party's inquisitor, occupies the structural position Donna occupies, while Julia occupies her affective one; and Winston's final love for Big Brother is the end of the subject as conversion, where Bruce's is the end of the subject as erasure. Orwell's doublethink is the voluntary discipline of holding contradictions; Arctor's is involuntary and cortical. G. K. Chesterton's *The Man Who Was Thursday: A Nightmare* (1908) is the deep comic ancestor: Gabriel Syme infiltrates the Central Anarchist Council and discovers that every member is an undercover detective, recruited in a darkened room by an unseen chief who proves to be identical with Sunday, the anarchists' president. Police all the way down, and the head of order and the head of chaos one person. Sunday's last words, from Mark 10:38, are a eucharistic question: "Can ye drink of the cup that I drink of?" Kafka's *Der Process* (1925) furnishes the chiasmus: Josef K. is

accused by a court whose charge he never learns; Arctor is the accuser who never learns that he is the accused.

Two later novels read as retrospective commentaries. Thomas Pynchon's *Inherent Vice* (2009), set in Los Angeles at the close of the 1960s, discloses the Golden Fang, an international heroin syndicate entwined with Chryskylodon — Greek, Pynchon notes, for "golden fang" — an institute for rehabilitation and psychological reprogramming; the cartel profits from addiction and from its treatment, and a right-wing civilian militia recruits a heroin addict as an informant on the counterculture. It is New-Path reconceived as a vertically integrated enterprise. David Foster Wallace's *Infinite Jest* (1996) centers on a halfway house whose residents capitalize their "Substance"; on a film so pleasurable that it kills; on a federal agent operating in elaborate disguise; and, in its chronologically final scene, on Hal Incandenza, whose rich interior life is perceived by others only as grotesque noise and flailing. Hal is Bruce's inverse: an intact interior behind a ruined exterior, where Bruce is a functioning exterior around an evacuated interior.

04 The Undercover Soul and Mimetic Forgetting

John le Carré's *The Spy Who Came in from the Cold* (1963) is the espionage novel whose structure *A Scanner Darkly* most precisely reproduces. Alec Leamas simulates alcoholic decline and disgrace in order to attract recruitment by East German intelligence; the operation's true purpose, the protection of a double agent, is concealed from him; he is expendable, and he dies at the Wall. The agent's degradation is the instrument of an operation whose meaning is withheld from him — except that Leamas performs his decline, while Arctor's is real. Gene Wolfe's *The Fifth Head of Cerberus* (1972) carries the logic of disguise to its limit. On the colony world of Sainte Anne, Veil's Hypothesis holds that the shape-shifting aborigines killed the human settlers and imitated them so perfectly that they forgot they were imitating; the anthropologist John Marsch may himself have been so replaced. Mimesis carried through to forgetting is the undercover agent's terminal risk, and it is Arctor's fate: the role of the user, played in order to be undone, cannot be undone. The constellation's two oldest stars in this sector — Odysseus disguised as a beggar in his own house and recognized only by the scar his nurse finds while washing his feet, and the prince of the Gnostic Hymn of the Pearl who disguises himself in the garments of Egypt and forgets who he is — are reserved for Chapter VIII, where they will govern the reading of the ending.

05 Paranoia and the Image

Pynchon's *The Crying of Lot 49* (1966) gives the paranoid hermeneutic its Oedipal heroine, Oedipa Maas, who can never decide whether the Tristero is real, a hoax, or her own projection; *Gravity's Rainbow* (1973), published as Dick drafted his novel, gives it a protagonist, Tyrone Slothrop, who was conditioned in infancy by an industrial chemist and who, by the novel's end, has literally scattered across the Zone. Barris is the household's Pynchonian hermeneut, and Slothrop's dispersal is the closest contemporaneous analogue to Arctor's. J. G. Ballard's *The Atrocity Exhibition* (1970) applies a scramble suit to the proper name: its protagonist is Travis in one section, Talbot or Traven or Talbert in another, a single consciousness distributed across mutating designations. Lem's *Solaris* (1961) gives the scanner its cosmic form: an ocean that reads the scientists' memories and materializes them as visitors, prompting the reflection, voiced by Snaut, that humanity seeks not other worlds but mirrors. Dick's apparatus returns only mirrors, and the image in them cannot be recognized. William Gibson's *Neuromancer* (1984) presents the obverse of Dick's operation: a hacker whose nervous system was damaged as punishment is restored by an artificial intelligence that has orchestrated his life for its own liberation. Gibson's invisible operation redeems; Dick's consumes.

06 Elegies of the Counterculture

Three elegies for the 1960s were written within a decade of one another. Joan Didion's "Slouching Towards Bethlehem" (1967), borrowing Yeats's apocalypse for its title, reports the atomization of Haight-Ashbury in a register of cool moral alarm. Hunter S. Thompson's *Fear and Loathing in Las Vegas* (1971) contains the passage on the high-water mark, the point at which the wave of the decade broke and rolled back, in a register of lyrical, gonzo romanticism. Dick's Author's Note is neither reportorial nor lyrical but liturgical: a roll call of names, each followed by an injury, ending with the author's own. The difference of register is a difference of genre. Didion's essay is journalism and Thompson's novel is picaresque; Dick's note belongs to the order of commemoration, the reading aloud of the names of the dead within a rite. Chapter VII will identify the rite.

CHAPTER SEVEN

VII

Nobody's Eucharist

A Negative Corinthian Reading



δοκιμαζέτω δὲ ἄνθρωπος ἑαυτόν

But let a man examine himself.

1 CORINTHIANS 11:28

The title of *A Scanner Darkly* is taken from the thirteenth chapter of the First Epistle to the Corinthians; the last word of its narrative returns the reader to the eleventh. This chapter reads the span between them, 1 Corinthians 11:17–13:13, as the novel's covert architecture. It shows that every term of Paul's argument — consumption, self-examination, discernment of the body, schism, care, the imputation of evil, the mirror, the face — reappears in Dick's Orange County as its technological or institutional counterfeit, and that the novel is in consequence a negative liturgy: Nobody's Eucharist.

01 The Epistle as Architecture

Paul wrote to Corinth in the mid-50s to a community riven by factions, and chapters 11 through 13 form a single continuous argument. It opens with the report that there are *schismata*, divisions, among them when they come together to eat (11:18). It transmits the words spoken over the bread and the cup — the earliest written account we possess, older than any Gospel — with the command to do this *eis tēn emēn anamnēsin*, in remembrance of me (11:23–26). It warns that those who eat and drink without discerning the body eat and drink judgment, and that this is why many are weak and sickly and many sleep (11:27–32). Chapter 12 develops the community as one body of many members, among whom there must be no schism. Chapter 13 sets love above knowledge and closes on the mirror, the riddle, and the face. Consumption, body, love: the novel's title opens this argument at its end, and the novel's last word reopens it at its beginning.

Whether Dick intended the correspondences mapped below is not the question this chapter asks. The grammar of the epistle was the grammar of the Christianity Dick practiced in the 1960s and had already dramatized in *The Three Stigmata of Palmer Eldritch*, whose rival drugs parody the controversies of the Supper; his title cites the letter; and the structural homologies are too numerous and too exact to be dismissed as accident without becoming, for that very reason, more interesting. The claim is that the epistle supplies the coordinates within which the novel's design becomes legible as a whole.

02 *Dokimazetō heauton*: Self-Examination as Surveillance

"But let a man examine himself, and so let him eat of that bread, and drink of that cup" (11:28). Paul's verb, *dokimazein*, means to test or assay, as metal is assayed for purity; and in the civic vocabulary of the Greek city its cognate *dokimasia* named the formal scrutiny to which an Athenian was subjected before taking office, a public and quasi-forensic examination of fitness. Paul interiorizes the scrutiny: the

communicant conducts his own *dokimasia* before he eats. The Christian West elaborated the injunction into its most consequential technology of the self — Augustine's turn inward (*Noli foras ire, in te ipsum redi; in interiore homine habitat veritas*: do not go outside; return into yourself; truth dwells in the inner man, *De vera religione* 39.72), the examination of conscience, Ignatius of Loyola's daily examen, the Puritan diary of self-scrutiny — the lineage Foucault traced as the hermeneutics of the subject.

Arctor's self-surveillance is the *dokimasia* returned from the conscience to the city, and from the first person to the third. The self is examined not from within but from without, through an apparatus; not by the self but by its institutional double; and not as preparation for communion but as its substitute. Augustine's *redi in te ipsum* is reversed into an injunction to leave oneself in order to find oneself on a monitor. Kierkegaard defined the self as a relation that relates itself to itself — *Selvet er et Forhold, der forholder sig til sig selv* — and despair as a misrelation within that relation (*Sygdommen til Døden*, 1849). In Arctor the self's relation to itself runs through an apparatus owned by another; the relation breaks at the point of mediation; and what follows is the form of despair Kierkegaard judged the most common and the furthest from deliverance, the despair that does not know it is despair. Bruce is its final figure. Augustine wrote, after the death of a friend, that he had become a great question to himself (*factus eram ipse mihi magna quaestio*, *Confessions* IV.4.9). The Author's Note is written from the same place.

03 *Mē diakrinōn to sōma*: Not Discerning the Body

"For he that eateth and drinketh unworthily, eateth and drinketh damnation to himself, not discerning the Lord's body" (11:29). The verb *diakrinein* means to distinguish, to discern, to judge between; and the body to be discerned is, in Paul's argument, at least threefold: the sacramental body of the bread; the ecclesial body of the community — "Now ye are the body of Christ" (12:27); and, implicitly, the communicant's own body, which an earlier chapter called a temple (6:19). Exegetes dispute which is meant. The ambiguity is generative, and Dick's novel fails all three discernments at once.

It fails the sacramental discernment: Substance D is consumed by people who do not know what it is or where it comes from, and its source, the cultivated body of the plant, is hidden in a field belonging to the institution that claims to heal its consumers. It fails the ecclesial discernment: the household is a community incapable of discerning its own members — who is an informant, who a narcotics agent, who a federal operative — so that the table at which they share their drugs is a table of schisms. And it fails the personal discernment with a literalness Paul

could not have imagined: a man sits before a monitor, looks at his own body, and does not discern it. The Pauline pathology has become a scene.

Two verses later Paul names the remedy: *εἰ δὲ ἑαυτοὺς διεκρίνομεν, οὐκ ἂν ἐκρινόμεθα* — "For if we would judge ourselves, we should not be judged" (11:31). Self-discernment averts judgment. Dick inverts the logic exactly. Fred's discernment of himself, conducted as surveillance and filed as reports, becomes the dossier by which Arctor is judged. In Paul, those who judge themselves escape condemnation; in Dick, the self that examines itself on the State's behalf condemns itself. The strange phrase of 11:29, that the unworthy communicant eats and drinks *krima*, judgment, to himself, is literalized as well: Arctor consumes his own condemnation, the drug that makes him the operation's chosen instrument.

04 "Many Are Weak and Sickly Among You, and Many Sleep"

Διὰ τοῦτο ἐν ὑμῖν πολλοὶ ἀσθενεῖς καὶ ἄρρωστοι καὶ κοιμῶνται ἱκανοί — "For this cause many are weak and sickly among you, and many sleep" (11:30). Paul attributes illness and death within the community to an unworthy consumption. His verb for the dead, *koimōntai*, "they sleep," was the early Christian euphemism that gave the language *koimētērion*, the sleeping-place, the cemetery. The Author's Note is the epidemiology of 11:30: a list of the weak, the sickly, and those who sleep, each name followed by a permanent injury or by death, and the whole traced to a consumption. The structural identity is complete. And Dick's insistence that the dead were punished too much, rather than justly, is precisely the point at which the novel departs from Paul's theodicy while retaining his diagnosis.

The verb has a pre-Christian history Dick had made his own. Heraclitus wrote that the waking share one common world, but that each of the sleeping — *κοιμωμένων* — turns aside into a world of his own (DK B89); and Dick built his 1965 essay "Schizophrenia & The Book of Changes" on the distinction between the *koinos kosmos* and the *idios kosmos*. The household's sleepers each inhabit an *idios kosmos*: Jerry Fabin's aphids, Barris's conspiracies, Freck's extradimensional accuser. The scanner purports to restore the *koinos kosmos*, the shared and objective world of the record. But its world is not common. It is the State's *idios kosmos* presented as the common one. Gnostic literature drew the obverse of Paul's anthropology from the same images. Hans Jonas gathered, under the heading of numbness, sleep, and intoxication, the Gnostic figures of a humanity drunk on the wine of ignorance and asleep in the world, awaiting a call from without (*The Gnostic Religion*, 1958). Paul's sleepers are the dead of an unworthy meal; the Gnostics' are the living who have forgotten what they are. Dick's are both at once.

05 The Body That Is All Eye

"For as the body is one, and hath many members … If the whole body were an eye, where were the hearing?" (12:12, 17). "And the eye cannot say unto the hand, I have no need of thee: nor again the head to the feet, I have no need of you" (12:21). "That there should be no schism in the body; but that the members should have the same care one for another" — *ἵνα μὴ ᾖ σχίσμα ἐν τῷ σώματι, ἀλλὰ τὸ αὐτὸ ὑπὲρ ἀλλήλων μεριμνῶσιν τὰ μέλη* (12:25).

The surveillance society is Paul's monstrous hypothesis realized: a body that has become wholly eye. The agency is pure organ of sight. Its members do not know one another; it has no hearing for the persons it records and no hand to help them. Paul's word for the divisions at Corinth, *schisma*, belongs to the family from which the twentieth century coined its name for the split mind; and the novel relocates the schism from the community into the body of its protagonist, as a cortical *schisma* between hemispheres. Anatomically, the corpus callosum is the organ of 12:25, the great bundle of fibers through which the members of the brain "have the same care one for another." Substance D severs it.

The verse names the antidote to schism, and the antidote is care: *merimnōsin*, that the members may have the same care for one another. Chapter V found the drug's essence in the absence of care — Plato's *Ameles*, the loss of Heidegger's *Sorge*. The epistle supplies the third idiom. The novel's catastrophe has a single name in three languages — Platonic carelessness, Heideggerian ontological death, Pauline schism without care — and the antidote, if there is one, will have to be care. Verse 21 should be held in reserve. The head, Paul says, cannot say to the feet that it has no need of them. In the novel's final scene the head will have nothing left to say, and the feet will carry what remains.

06 Love Keeps No Ledger

Among the attributes of love in the thirteenth chapter is this: *οὐ λογίζεται τὸ κακόν* (13:5) — "thinketh no evil," in the Authorized Version, but more exactly, love does not reckon evil, does not keep an account of wrongs. *Logizesthai* is the verb of bookkeeping and of the courts: to calculate, to reckon, to impute. Paul uses it in Romans for the imputation of righteousness: Abraham believed God, and it was reckoned (*elogisthē*) to him for righteousness (Rom 4:3, citing Gen 15:6). The Reformation built its doctrine of justification on this verb. Melanchthon's *Apology of the Augsburg Confession* (1531) specifies that "to justify," in forensic usage — *forensi consuetudine* — means to acquit a guilty man and pronounce him righteous on account of an alien righteousness; Luther spoke of a *iustitia aliena*, imputed rather

than possessed, under which the believer is at once righteous and a sinner. Forensic justification makes identity — righteous or guilty — a declaration of the court, independent of the interior state of the one declared.

Forensic apperception is the secular inversion of forensic justification. The State reckons evil to the subject: Arctor is declared a suspect, his acts are recorded and imputed, and his interior state, which the apparatus cannot see, is irrelevant to the declaration. Barris keeps a ledger of wrongs; the scanner keeps a better one. Against both, the hymn sets a love that does not reckon. Its counter-virtue to surveillance is not concealment but non-imputation: love declines to keep the record. The surrounding verses complete the antithesis. Love "believeth all things, hopeth all things" (13:7), where paranoia believes nothing it is told and suspects everything it sees. Paul Ricoeur named Marx, Nietzsche, and Freud the masters of suspicion (*De l'interprétation*, 1965). Barris is suspicion's degenerate master, and the holo-scanner is suspicion automated. Hogg's justified sinner, considered in Chapter VI, stands at the hinge of the two forensic regimes: a man assured by the doctrine of imputed righteousness of his election, and destroyed by imputed crimes, committed by a double he cannot remember.

07 Mask to Mask

Chapter IV read the scramble suit as the parody of *prosōpon pros prosōpon*. Emmanuel Levinas formulated the ethical stakes of that parody. For Levinas the face of the other, in its nakedness and destitution, resists every attempt to possess, comprehend, or totalize it, and signifies, before any word, the prohibition of murder; ethics, as first philosophy, begins in the face-to-face (*Totalité et infini*, 1961). The scramble suit is the technological abolition of the face. A face composed of all faces is the face of no one, and it can command nothing. The novel's world is a world without the face: Fred and Hank never see each other; Donna refuses to be touched; Arctor sees his own face only as footage. In Levinasian terms it is a world in which ethics has been replaced by observation.

The chapter of the epistle that contains the face-to-face also contains the sentence that governs the novel's ending. Love never fails, Paul writes, "but whether there be knowledge, it shall vanish away" — *εἴτε γνῶσις, καταργηθήσεται* (13:8); knowledge is partial and will pass; "And now abideth faith, hope, charity, these three; but the greatest of these is charity" (13:13). The last page of *A Scanner Darkly* enacts 13:8 with clinical literalness: Bruce's knowledge has vanished away. Whether something of charity abides is the question of Chapter VIII.

08 Desubstantiation

The Council of Trent defined the eucharistic change as the conversion of the whole substance of the bread into the substance of Christ's body, the appearances of bread remaining, and named it transubstantiation (Session XIII, 1551). Thomas Aquinas had analyzed the consequence with characteristic rigor: after the consecration the accidents of bread — its color, taste, and extension — remain without a subject in which to inhere, sustained by divine power (*Summa Theologiae* III, qq. 75–77). The novel contains both halves of the scholastic doctrine, and inverts each.

The scramble suit is accidents without a subject: features, colors, and shapes persisting with no substance in which they inhere, sustained not by divine power but by a data bank. The State performs by technology the miracle the scholastics reserved to God. Substance D is the converse: the conversion of the whole substance of a person while his accidents remain. Bruce has Arctor's body, gait, and voice, but not Arctor's substance. This is not transubstantiation, the conversion of a substance into a higher one, but *desubstantiation*: the conversion of a substance into nothing, the appearances remaining. The drug's name now reads as a theological term, and its street name inverts the oldest pharmacological description of the Eucharist. Ignatius of Antioch, on his way to martyrdom, called the bread broken in the assembly *φάρμακον ἀθανασίας, ἀντίδοτος τοῦ μὴ ἀποθανεῖν* — the medicine of immortality, the antidote that we should not die (*Ephesians* 20.2). The eucharistic *pharmakon* confers deathlessness. *Mors ontologica* confers the death of being.

Dick's corpus had approached this inversion twice before. *Palmer Eldritch* made the anti-Eucharist explicit and demonic; *Ubik* imagined its positive, a sacrament in a spray can. *A Scanner Darkly* naturalizes and institutionalizes the anti-Eucharist: no devil presides over it, only an organization. German Romanticism supplies the positive pole of the constellation. Novalis's *Hymnen an die Nacht* (1800) bind night, death, the lost beloved, and *dem braunen Safte des Mohns*, the brown juice of the poppy, into a mysticism of reunion with the dead, and his *Geistliche Lieder* include a hymn on the Supper as a mystery of love known to few. The Romantic Eucharist of night is the photographic positive of which Dick's novel is the negative; its emblem, the blue flower, will return at the novel's close. And Marx's formula is completed in reverse: in a novel in which the church grows the poppy, opium is no longer the religion of the people but its counter-sacrament.

09 The Corinthian Matrix

The correspondences can now be set out together.

VERSE	PAULINE TERM	FUNCTION IN THE EPISTLE	COUNTERFEIT IN THE NOVEL
11:18	*schismata*	divisions at the common meal	a household of informants, agents, and users
11:24	*eucharistēsas, anamnēsis*	thanksgiving and remembrance	Thanksgiving anticipated by a man without memory
11:28	*dokimazetō heauton*	self-examination before eating	self-surveillance by apparatus
11:29	*mē diakrinōn to sōma*	failure to discern the body	Fred cannot recognize his own body on screen
11:30	*koimōntai*	many sick, many asleep	the Author's Note's roll call of the damaged and the dead
11:31	*heautous diekrinomen*	self-judgment averts judgment	self-reporting compiles the dossier that condemns
12:17	*holon to sōma ophthalmos*	a body that is all eye is monstrous	the agency as pure organ of sight
12:25	*schisma, merimnōsin*	no schism; mutual care	cortical schism; the extinction of care
13:5	*ou logizetai to kakon*	love keeps no ledger	the informant's ledger and the State's file
13:8	*gnōsis katargēthēsetai*	knowledge will pass away	Bruce's knowledge has passed away
13:12	*di' esoptrou en ainigmati*	the dark mirror of the present	the holo-scanner
13:12	*prosōpon pros prosōpon*	the eschatological face-to-face	Fred and Hank, mask to mask
13:12	*epignōsomai kathōs kai epegnōsthēn*	to know as one is known by God	to know oneself as one is known by the State

Read through this matrix, *A Scanner Darkly* is a negative liturgy. Its consumption is anti-sacramental, its self-examination forensic, its body schismatic, its ledger unforgiving, its mirror dark, its face a mask, and its dead, like Paul's, asleep. One row remains open. The epistle's sequence begins with a thanksgiving and a remembrance, and the novel ends with the anticipation of a Thanksgiving by a man who cannot remember. Whether that row, too, is counterfeit, or whether it is the one place in the novel where the counterfeit fails, is the question of the next chapter.

CHAPTER EIGHT

VIII

The Blue Flower

Acephalic Anamnesis and the Gift Given in Forgetting



τοῦτο ποιεῖτε εἰς τὴν ἐμὴν ἀνάμνησιν

This do in remembrance of me.

1 CORINTHIANS 11:24



The novel ends with a man who no longer exists performing an act that the whole apparatus of the novel cannot see. This chapter reads that act: first in its literal circumstances; then through the ancient narratives of forgetting and recognition it re-enacts; then through the modern theory of the gift; and finally as the answer the novel gives to the question with which the philosophy of personal identity left it. The answer is care, and its form is what I call *acephalic anamnesis*.

01 The Scene

The final chapter places Bruce among the rows of a New-Path farm. Kneeling, he sees close to the ground a small blue flower and announces, in two words, that he has seen. His interior narration registers death rising out of the soil itself, a whole field of it, blue. Two New-Path functionaries exchange a glance and look down at the kneeling man and at the *Mors ontologica* planted everywhere within the concealing corn; they see a burned-out resident on his knees, and nothing more. Bruce picks one of the plants and slips it down into his right shoe, out of sight. It is a present for his friends, he thinks; and he looks forward, inside his mind, "where no one could see," to Thanksgiving.

The scene must be read against what the reader already knows. Shortly before, Donna and the federal agent Mike Westaway have rehearsed the operation's logic: New-Path admits only the harmless and the burned-out; there was no other way in; Arctor was spent so that someone might see. The act is accordingly overdetermined. It fulfills the State's instrumental plan — the evidence has been seen and secured, and the "friends" to whom it will be carried may be the agents themselves, as some readers have concluded. And it is the residual act of a self: a gift, reserved for a feast, for friends. The scene poses, in a new form, the question that has haunted the novel since its opening pages: who acts? This chapter answers that no one does — and argues that this is the point.

One textual fact must be underlined before any interpretation. The last space the novel opens is a space no one can see. The counterfeit eschaton, whose ambition was total visibility, is breached on the final page by an interiority — not the vast inner palace of Augustine's memory, but a minimal one, containing nothing but the anticipation of a feast. Locke deferred the laying open of the secrets of all hearts to the Great Day. The novel ends with one secret kept.

02 Anamnesis and the Saved Tale

Plato held that seeking and learning are wholly recollection, *anamnēsis*: the soul recovers in this life what it knew before birth and forgot in embodiment (*Meno* 81c–d; *Phaedo* 72e–76e). In the Myth of Er the instrument of forgetting is the River Ameles, and Er alone is not permitted to drink. He wakes on his funeral pyre and reports what he saw, and Socrates concludes: *μῦθος ἐσώθη καὶ οὐκ ἀπώλετο* — the tale was saved and not lost, and it will save us if we are persuaded by it (621b–c). Er is the one who returns from the plain of Lethe with memory intact, in order to tell. Bruce has drunk, and more than the measure. Yet he too carries something back from the field: not a tale, which he could not tell, but a token. Dick would later adopt *anamnesis* as his term for the experiences of 1974, the loss of forgetting, in *VALIS* and throughout the *Exegesis*. The anamnesis of *A Scanner Darkly* is pretheophanic: no illumination, no revelation, only a gesture.

03 The Hymn of the Pearl

The so-called Hymn of the Pearl, preserved in the apocryphal *Acts of Thomas* (108–113) and probably composed in the third century, is antiquity's most perfect narrative of Gnostic forgetting, and its structure is that of *A Scanner Darkly* with uncanny exactness. A royal son of the East is sent by his parents into Egypt to bring back the one pearl that lies in the midst of the sea, beside a loud-breathing serpent. He lays aside his robe of glory, which will await his return. In Egypt he clothes himself in garments like the Egyptians', so that they will not recognize him as a stranger come to take the pearl: he goes undercover. They discover nonetheless that he is not one of them; they deal with him treacherously and give him their food; and he forgets that he is a king's son, serves their king, forgets the pearl, and falls into deep sleep under the weight of their food. His parents send a letter, which flies like an eagle and becomes speech beside him: awake, remember that you are a king's son, remember the pearl. He wakes, remembers, charms the serpent by naming his father's name, seizes the pearl, strips off the filthy garments, and returns. His robe comes to meet him, and in it he sees himself as in a mirror: two in distinction, one in likeness.

The homology runs through seven terms. A sovereign power sends an agent into hostile territory to retrieve a precious thing. The agent disguises himself in local clothing to avoid detection as an outsider. The enemy's food induces forgetting of identity and mission. The agent comes to serve the enemy's king: Bruce labors for New-Path. He sleeps. The precious thing lies guarded within the enemy's territory: the source of Substance D, coiled within the institution. He retrieves it. Two

terms are missing. No letter comes — no call from without, no eagle, no speech that wakes him; Bruce seizes the pearl in his sleep. And the robe that mirrors the self, two in distinction and one in likeness, never arrives: Fred and Arctor are never reunited in a single likeness. The text in which the Hymn survives bears the name of Thomas, which means "twin" in Aramaic, as *Didymus* does in Greek; in the Gnostic imagination the redeemer is the self's heavenly twin, and recognition of the twin is salvation. Dick's novel is the Hymn of the Pearl without the twin's recognition.

Hans Jonas analyzed the Hymn at length, and it was through Jonas, among others, that Dick by the time of *VALIS* possessed this material. The claim here is homology, not influence: *A Scanner Darkly* is the Hymn of the Pearl suspended between the sleep and the letter. And Dick's biography supplies the missing term with eerie punctuality. The letter arrived for the author — as a pharmacy delivery, an *ichthys* pendant, and a loss of forgetting — between the novel's draft and its revisions. The author received the call his protagonist never hears.

04 The Lotus-Eater Who Wants to Go Home

The lotus, Homer says, made those who ate it forget their homecoming (*Odyssey* 9.97). Bruce has eaten the lotus. Yet the last thing in his mind is a homecoming feast. Thanksgiving, proclaimed a national holiday by Lincoln in 1863, is the American festival of return, the day on which the dispersed travel home to eat together. The lotus-eater still wants to go home, and wants to bring the lotus as a present. *Nostos* survives the lotus — not as memory of home, which is gone, but as anticipation of a table and of friends at it. The Homeric antithesis between forgetting and homecoming, on which the moral economy of the *Odyssey* rests, is quietly broken: the novel imagines a homecoming that requires no memory.

05 The Scar and the Shoe

In the nineteenth book of the *Odyssey*, Odysseus, disguised as a beggar in his own house and unrecognized even by Penelope, is recognized by his old nurse Eurycleia, who, washing his feet, touches the scar left by a boar's tusk in his youth and lets the foot fall so that the basin overturns. Aristotle cites the scene as recognition by signs (*sēmeia*), the least artful kind and the most bodily (*Poetics* 16); Erich Auerbach made it the opening scene of his history of Western realism (*Mimesis*, 1946). The token of recognition, the *gnōrisma*, is located at the foot, and recognition takes place at the washing of the feet. In the Fourth Gospel, which replaces

the words over the bread and the cup with a different sign, the Last Supper is the occasion on which the master washes his disciples' feet (John 13).

Bruce conceals the flower in his shoe. The only sign by which this man might later be recognized — and by which he might recognize what he has seen — travels at the foot. Paul's sentence returns: the head cannot say to the feet, I have no need of you (1 Cor 12:21). In Bruce the head has nothing left to say. The feet carry the *gnōrisma*.

This is the structure I call *acephalic anamnesis*: remembrance carried by the body and the deed, below the head, in the absence of a self-conscious rememberer. Its first philosophical warrant is Bergson's distinction, in *Matière et mémoire* (1896), between the memory that represents — the image of the past recalled as past — and the memory that acts, the habit stored in motor mechanisms like a lesson learned by heart. Merleau-Ponty extended the analysis into an account of the habit body, a knowledge that lives in the hands and feet before it is thought (*Phénoménologie de la perception*, 1945). Bruce's gesture is habit-memory in this sense, and doubly: the agent's trained reflex to secure evidence and the friend's trained reflex to bring a gift persist as motor schemata after representation has gone, and they converge in a single movement of the hand toward the shoe. Its emblem is Georges Bataille's *Acéphale* (1936–1939), the headless figure André Masson drew for Bataille's review, who stood for a sovereignty freed from the head's servitude to utility, and whose economy, set out in *La part maudite* (1949), was expenditure without return.

06 The Blue Flower

Novalis's *Heinrich von Ofterdingen* (1802) opens with a dream. Heinrich comes upon a tall, pale blue flower beside a spring; as he gazes at it, it bends toward him, and its petals open into a blue collar *in welchem ein zartes Gesicht schwebte* — in which a delicate face hovered. The face is that of the beloved he has yet to meet, and the *blaue Blume* became the emblem of Romantic longing for the infinite. Earlier commentary has registered the resonance of Dick's blue flower with German Romanticism; the face within Novalis's flower allows the resonance to be specified. Dick's blue flower is the flower of defacement. The drug it yields abolishes faces, in the suit's composite and in the burnout's vacancy. Yet in the final gesture the flower is directed toward faces: friends. The face in the flower returns not as the image of a beloved but as the destination of a gift, and the Romantic infinite is contracted to the finite. Not the absolute: a holiday dinner.

Four further stars complete this sector of the constellation. Proust's narrator first sees Gilberte through a hedge of hawthorn — and the beloved of Dick's novel

is named Hawthorne — and Proust's account of involuntary memory, released by a material trigger rather than summoned by will, suggests what a flower in a shoe might one day become: a madeleine, in a future the novel declines to narrate. Daniel Keyes's diminished narrator closes *Flowers for Algernon* by asking that flowers be placed on a grave in the backyard; the last act of the ruined subject is care, and its vehicle is a flower. Camus asked his reader to attend to Sisyphus not on the ascent but on the descent, in the pause that is the hour of consciousness (*Le mythe de Sisyphe*, 1942); Bruce's kneeling is his descent. And Walter Benjamin proposed, in his essay on Surrealism (1929), that the true overcoming of religious illumination lies in a profane illumination, a materialist and anthropological inspiration to which hashish or opium can give an introductory lesson — a dangerous one. Bruce's moment is a profane illumination at the bottom of the drug's ruin: he sees, in a field, death rising from the soil.

07 The Gift Given in Forgetting

Marcel Mauss showed that the gift creates obligation — to give, to receive, to return — and that the thing given carries a force that seeks its way back to its source; the gift is the matrix of social bonds and of economy (*Essai sur le don*, 1925). Derrida drew from Mauss's analysis the aporia of the gift (*Donner le temps*, 1991). As soon as a gift appears as a gift, to donor or donee, it is annulled: it enters the circle of exchange as debt, gratitude, or self-congratulation, and returns. For there to be a gift, Derrida concludes, there must be an absolute forgetting on both sides — not repression, which preserves what it hides, but a forgetting beyond the psychological, which leaves no trace that could be repaid.

Every relation in *A Scanner Darkly* is an exchange. Drugs are dealt for money; information is traded for standing; affection is withheld or simulated; the agency spends a man for a probability. Barris informs in order to rise; Donna's intimacy is an operation; Arctor exchanges his identity for access. In this economy one act stands outside the circle, and it is possible because of *Mors ontologica*. The donor has forgotten himself. He cannot recognize his gift as a gift, cannot congratulate himself on it, cannot expect its return; he may not know who his friends are. The condition Derrida names as the gift's impossible precondition — absolute forgetting — is precisely what the drug manufactures. The poison becomes the gift's condition. The pharmakon turns over a final time.

The undecidability must not be resolved. The same flower may be evidence for the agency and a present for friends; the gift and the evidence are one object, and the novel declines to say which it is. This refusal is the pharmakon's final form,

and it is where the novel's ethics lives: in a thing that is at once the State's harvest and a friend's offering, carried by someone who no longer belongs to either.

08 Care After Identity

Chapter II left the philosophy of personal identity with Parfit: identity is not what matters; what matters is psychological connectedness and continuity. Bruce has neither identity nor connectedness. What remains is care. Harry Frankfurt's "Freedom of the Will and the Concept of a Person" (1971), written in the years of the novel's gestation, built its account of personhood on three addicts: the unwilling addict, who desires the drug and wills not to desire it; the willing addict, who endorses his desire; and the wanton, who has no second-order volitions at all and is therefore, in Frankfurt's sense, not a person. Arctor's history, read through Frankfurt, is the passage from unwilling addict to wanton. But Frankfurt's later work grounded the will less in reflective endorsement than in caring, in what we care about ("The Importance of What We Care About," 1982). Bruce's gesture shows care persisting after reflection has vanished: a wanton who still cares. Frankfurt's taxonomy has no place for him. Dick's novel insists on him.

Heidegger named the mode of care directed toward others *Fürsorge*, solicitude (*Sein und Zeit* §26). Bruce's gift is solicitude without a Dasein to own it. Levinas, in the book he published in 1974, the year of the novel's revisions, relocated subjectivity from consciousness to substitution: the self as for-the-other before it is for-itself, a hostage, tearing the bread from its own mouth to give it (*Autrement qu'être ou au-delà de l'essence*). Bruce realizes Levinas's thesis with terrible literalness: a subject that is for-the-other after it has ceased to be for-itself. Paul's chapter supplies the frame. The members of the body are to have the same care one for another (12:25); knowledge shall vanish away (13:8); charity abides (13:13). Bruce's knowledge has vanished. Something of charity remains.

Paul's chapter also raises the strongest objection to this reading, and it must be met. "And though I bestow all my goods to feed the poor … and have not charity, it profiteth me nothing" — *οὐδὲν ὠφελοῦμαι* (13:3). Giving is not enough; it must be done in love. Bruce gives without a self, which seems to fail the condition. But the verse measures the gift by what it profits the giver, and profit to the giver is exactly what Bruce can no longer have. What remains in him is affection for friends without an ego to be repaid. His gift meets Paul's condition by the only route the novel leaves open: charity without a self to profit from it.

The third concept of this study can now be defined. *Acephalic anamnesis* is a remembrance enacted by the body and the deed in the absence of a self-conscious rememberer, directed toward others, whose content is not a representation of the

past but an orientation of care toward a future feast. It is the novel's only eschatology: an eschatology without vision, since there is no face-to-face; without knowledge, since knowledge has vanished; consisting of a single act of thanksgiving. In the epistle, the Lord, *eucharistēsas* — having given thanks — broke the bread and commanded that it be done *eis anamnēsin* (1 Cor 11:24). Bruce's Thanksgiving is Nobody's Eucharist: anamnesis without a rememberer, thanksgiving without a thanker, the poison carried toward the table as the possible antidote. If the flower reaches those who can trace its source, the pharmakon of ontological death becomes, for others, a *pharmakon athanasias*.

CHAPTER NINE

IX

Conclusion

Er's Return



μῦθος ἐσώθη καὶ οὐκ ἀπώλετο

The tale was saved and was not lost.

PLATO, REPUBLIC 621B

The argument closes where the book does, with the Author's Note. This chapter reads the Note as the liturgical completion of the work, identifies the two kinds of record between which the novel moves, and draws the consequences for four fields of inquiry.

01 The Author's Note as Diptych

In the early Christian liturgies the names of those to be commemorated, living and dead, were inscribed on hinged tablets, *diptychs*, and read aloud within the eucharistic prayer. The Roman Canon preserves the practice in its Memento of the Dead, which asks God to remember his servants who have gone before with the sign of faith *et dormiunt in somno pacis* — and sleep the sleep of peace. It is followed at once by the *Nobis quoque peccatoribus*, in which the celebrant prays for himself and the living: "to us also, sinners." The Book of Common Prayer of the Episcopal Church, the rite Dick knew, likewise blesses God's name, within the communion, for all his servants departed this life.

The Author's Note is a diptych. It is a list of names, each with its condition, read at the end of a work whose last word is Thanksgiving; its sleepers are Paul's *koimōmenoi*. The novel thus completes itself in the order of the rite: the narrative's *eucharistia*, followed by the commemoration of the dead. Dick's inclusion of himself among the injured, after the dead, occupies the place of the *Nobis quoque peccatoribus*: the one who offers counts himself among those for whom the offering is made. And his declaration that he is not a character in the novel but the novel itself is the celebrant's: not a figure within the rite but the one who performs it.

02 Dick as Er

Er returned from the plain of Lethe without having drunk, and told the living what he had seen; the tale was saved. Dick returned from the field of his own Lethe — with damage, he records, to his pancreas — and told. The novel is the saved tale. Socrates' claim, that the tale will save us if we are persuaded by it, is the only claim the Author's Note makes: not a moral, which Dick explicitly refuses, but a salvage, offered in the hope that it may be believed.

One further structure of testimony clarifies the Note, and I state it with a limit. Primo Levi argued that the complete witnesses of the camps were those who did not return, and that the survivors speak by proxy for them (*I sommersi e i salvati*, 1986); Giorgio Agamben built *Quel che resta di Auschwitz* (1998) on that lacuna in testimony. I invoke the structure of testimony, not the history. A rehabilitation farm in Dick's California is not comparable to the camps, and this study deliber-

ately draws no such comparison. But the structure holds: Bruce has seen the source and cannot testify, and the Author's Note is testimony by proxy, given by a survivor for friends who cannot speak.

03 Two Records

The holo-scanner and the novel are both recording devices, and the difference between them is the book's final argument. The scanner's record is forensic. It imputes, it accuses, it reckons evil (*logizetai to kakon*). It is *hypomnēsis* in Thamus's sense, producing forgetting in the souls it records. And it is, in a sense Derrida made explicit, archontic: the Greek *arkheion*, from which "archive" derives, was the house of the *archons*, the magistrates who held and interpreted the official documents (*Mal d'archive*, 1995) — and Dick's later Gnosticism would name the powers of the Black Iron Prison archons as well. The novel's record is anamnetic. It remembers in order to commemorate rather than to accuse; it does not reckon evil, since it refuses the moral and insists that the punishment exceeded the fault; it is addressed to the dead and offered to the living.

The difference is not technological but directional. A record addressed to a court is forensic; the same record, addressed to the dead and given to friends, becomes anamnetic. *A Scanner Darkly* accepts the verdict of the *Phaedrus*: writing cannot restore memory, and the novel cannot restore the dead. But it redirects the pharmakon. It offers itself not as a substitute for memory but as a memorial in the eucharistic sense, a remembrance that makes present. The flower in Bruce's shoe and the book in the reader's hand are the same object: a pharmakon carried out of the field of death and offered to friends. The novel's ethics is the passage from Fred's reports to Dick's Note — from the forensic record to the anamnetic one.

Plato supplies the model for the relation between the two objects. In the *Charmides* Socrates claims to possess a remedy for headaches, a certain leaf, which works only when a charm (*epōidē*) is spoken with it, because the charm treats the soul as the leaf treats the body (155e–157c). The flower in the shoe is a leaf without its charm. The novel is the charm: the words without which the pharmakon Bruce carries cannot become a remedy.

04 Implications

For Dick studies, the argument relocates the novel. *A Scanner Darkly* is not the last secular novel but the first negative theology. The grammar of *VALIS* — anamnesis, archons, the call from without, the Empire that never ended — is present in the text of 1973–1975 as absence, and the hinge of 2-3-74 falls inside the novel's com-

position. The theological turn of the late work should therefore be read not as a rupture but as the arrival of a letter whose address the earlier novel had already written.

For the philosophy of personal identity, the novel proposes an answer that neither Locke nor Parfit gives. Against the memory criterion and against psychological connectedness, it suggests that what survives the dissolution of identity is care. Identity may not be what matters; care is what remains. The convergence of Frankfurt's late account of caring, Heidegger's solicitude, and Levinas's substitution outlines a philosophical program the novel anticipates in narrative form.

For surveillance studies, the scramble suit anticipates and inverts the "data double" of Kevin Haggerty and Richard Ericson's surveillant assemblage (2000): the data double is a person assembled from data; the scramble suit is data assembled into a person. Shoshana Zuboff's account of surveillance capitalism (2019), which monetizes the prediction of behavior, describes the counterfeit eschaton in its commercial form — total visibility of acts, no access to hearts. The novel's enduring contribution here is its distinction between two kinds of archive, those that impute and those that remember. In an age of total recording, that distinction is the political question of the archive.

For the theory of addiction, the antinomy between decision and disease that divides the Author's Note from the narrative is resolved, in the novel's own terms, neither by the will nor by the brain alone but by the community. Paul attributed sickness to a failure to discern the body, and the body he meant was, among other things, the community; the Lions Club address glosses the drug's initial as the desertion of friends; and the novel's last act is a gift to friends. Experimental work contemporaneous with the novel's publication — the "Rat Park" studies conducted by Bruce K. Alexander and colleagues at Simon Fraser University in the late 1970s — suggested that isolation, and not the substance alone, drives compulsive use. The novel reached the same conclusion by another road. Its answer to the drug is friendship.

05 Coda

Through a glass, darkly; then, face to face. Between the two, in Dick's Orange County, there is neither glass nor face, only a scanner and a mask. And at the very end, beneath the corn, below the head, in a shoe, a flower: a present for friends, reserved for a day of thanksgiving, carried by no one. That is Nobody's Thanksgiving. It is the only eschatology the novel permits — not the Great Day on which the secrets of all hearts are laid open, but an ordinary holiday toward which a heart that no longer knows itself carries, in a place no one can see, a gift.

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APPARATUS

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